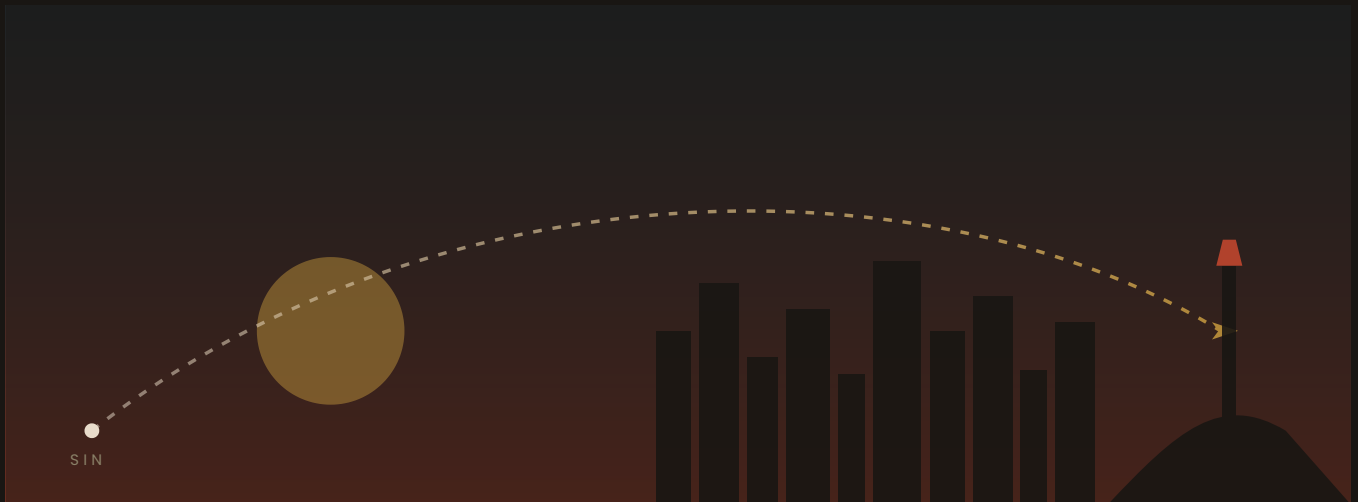


THE CURRENT BRIEFING OF

MERIDIAN

Twelve desks. One world.



THE GRAND TOUR · SIX HOURS NORTH

THE TRAVEL DESK

Seoul, the great city six hours north — and the honest case for going in October, not now

SCREEN & SOUND

Nolan's *Odyssey* becomes his biggest launch yet — and the theatre suddenly has a pulse again

CURIOSITIES

A line of Homer's *Iliad*, found tucked inside the wrappings of a 1,600-year-old mummy

THIS ISSUE · THE WEEKEND EDITION

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FROM THE DESK

"The Moving Finger writes; and, having writ, / Moves on: nor all thy Piety nor Wit / Shall lure it back to cancel half a Line, / Nor all thy Tears wash out a Word of it."

— Omar Khayyám, *Rubáiyát* (Edward FitzGerald trans., 1859)¹

A fitting couplet for a Saturday, when this desk keeps its own accounts. Below, The Scoreboard grades every call we made last issue — because a record, once written, does not un-write. The closing essay follows the impulse back to a tally stick and a weighed heart (p25).

BRENT CRUDE ~\$97 ▼	GOLD (XAU) ~\$4,070 ▲	BITCOIN ~\$64.3k ▼	USD/SGD 1.291	US 10-YEAR 4.71% ▲	STI 5,588 ▲
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THE SCOREBOARD

SATURDAY · WE GRADE OUR OWN CALLS · MISSES FIRST

- OUR MISS** **MACRO** The Fed holds on 29 July, "at ~83% odds."
The *call* (a hold) still stands, but we overpriced it: CME had it nearer 63%, with a rate **hike**, not a cut, the live tail. Regraded after the 29th. (No. 51, p15)²
- RIGHT** **TECHNOLOGY** DeepSeek's legacy API names stop resolving after 15:59 UTC, 24 July.
Retired to the minute; the aliases now fail. The one call fully due this week, and it landed. (No. 51, p8)³
- RIGHT · SO FAR** **THE WORLD** The ten-day Gulf ceasefire isn't accepted within a week.
Iran rejected the truce outright on 24 July. Unsigned; window closes 31 July. (No. 51, p3)⁴
- AHEAD** **SCREEN & SOUND** Spider-Man opens above US\$180m domestic.
Trackers now read \$230–250m+, so the bar looks soft — but it opens 31 July, and tracking isn't receipts. (No. 51, p12)⁵
- PENDING** **TECH · MACRO · PROPERTY · LONG READ** K3 ships Mon; MAS holds Mon; Dunearn sells >half today; the West writes up guzi in four weeks.
All open — K3 on track (27 Jul); MAS Monday (hold consensus); Dunearn books today; guzi window to 24 Aug. Marked next

SOURCES ¹ Omar Khayyám, *Rubáiyát*, quatrain 51, Edward FitzGerald translation (1st ed. 1859). ² CME FedWatch via CoinGape, 23–24 Jul 2026 (~63% hold vs ~36% hike into the 28–29 Jul FOMC); No. 51 predictions ledger. ³ DeepSeek deprecation notice; DigitalApplied / Developers Digest migration guides, 2026 (deepseek-chat / -reasoner retired 15:59 UTC 24 Jul). ⁴ Times of Israel / NYT (via UNN), 24 Jul 2026 (Iran rejects the US/Iraqi-brokered ceasefire). ⁵ Deadline; Box Office Pro long-range, Jul 2026 (\$230–250m+ tracking — projection, not result). ⁶ Moonshot / TechTimes (K3 open weights 27 Jul); Reuters MAS poll (12 of 16 expect hold, 27 Jul); 99.co / EdgeProp (Dunearn House books 25 Jul, ~5,900 preview visitors); guzi-coverage watch to 24 Aug. Market strip: TradingEconomics, CNBC, Yahoo Finance — levels at the 24 Jul close, subject to change (p15).

THE WORLD · THE GULF WAR

Tehran Says No, and the Barrel Cools

A month into a war that runs through both straits, Iran rejected the Iraqi-brokered ten-day truce on Friday — even as oil, which had touched a hundred dollars on the fear, gave back four per cent, the market pricing the next tanker rather than this one.

The word that would have stopped it was said on Friday, and the word was no. Iraq's prime minister carried a United States ceasefire proposal to Tehran — ten days of quiet and a reopened Strait of Hormuz — and Iran turned it down, unwilling to accept what it called a "temporary deal" that left the strait's status unresolved.¹ It was the war's clearest fork in a fortnight, and Iran took the harder road. The rejection landed as US forces pressed a thirteenth consecutive night of strikes and President Trump, having declared the earlier interim truce "over," said plainly: "We attacked Kharg Island last night," and mused that Washington might simply "take over" the island that handles the bulk of Iran's oil exports — "there's not a thing they can do about it."²

And yet the barrel, which usually amplifies this kind of week, did the opposite. Brent had punched back above US\$100 midweek when Kharg was hit; by Friday's close it had fallen about four per cent to roughly US\$97, with West Texas near US\$88 — still up something like 38 per cent on the month, but pointed down on the day.³ The market, in other

words, is pricing the fear of a closed strait, not its fact: Iran keeps shipping crude to China through the same water it threatens, and Bushehr's deputy governor claimed Kharg's "exports, imports and activities" were proceeding normally after the strike. The premium is real; the catastrophe it implies has not arrived. What it does reach, unfailingly, is the world's central banks (p15).

~38%

BRENT'S GAIN ON THE MONTH EVEN AFTER FRIDAY'S ~4% FALL TO ~US\$97 — A WAR PREMIUM PRICED OFF THE NEXT TANKER, NOT THE BARRELS ACTUALLY LOST FROM THIS ONE.

Read on a quiet Saturday, the shape of it is almost legible: a conflict now old enough to have a rhythm — strike, threaten, mediate, refuse — and an oil market learning, week by week, to discount the theatre. But a war that has found its equilibrium is not the same as one that is ending, and Kharg — spared as leverage one week, struck the next — is the pendulum everyone is watching. See p15 for the market read.

TRUCE REJECTED

OIL COOLS

KHARG IN PLAY

WASHINGTON

LEVERAGE FRAMING

The White House reads Kharg as coercion that works: hit the island that ships Iran's oil, and Tehran either bends on Hormuz or watches its one export lifeline burn. "Maybe we'll take over Kharg Island," Trump said; "there's not a thing they can do about it." In this telling the rejected truce is a bluff to be called, and the pressure is the policy — enough pain to force the deal Washington says is still there to be had.⁴

TEHRAN

STATE FRAMING

From Tehran the strait is the whole point, not a bargaining chip to be traded for ten quiet days. State television carried Mojtaba Khamenei's line that revenge "is the will of our nation and must certainly be carried out," and officials cast any ceasefire that leaves Hormuz's status open as surrender dressed as respite. Iran's message: it can throttle the world's outstanding chokepoint while still selling its own crude — so it will negotiate from the strait, not away from it.⁵

THE SCEPTIC

Mind the gap between the rhetoric and the tonnage. The Foundation for Defense of Democracies notes that ships are mostly rerouting pre-emptively rather than being sunk, and Friday's four-per-cent fall says the traders agree: this is a risk-and-insurance premium, not a physical closure.⁶ The louder tell is the one nobody frames as good news — a demand-side reading in which crude is soft because the world economy is, five straight IEA demand downgrades doing quiet work under the war headlines. The barrel may be pricing weakness, not just danger.

SOURCES 1 Times of Israel; New York Times via UNN, 24 Jul 2026 (Iran rejects US ceasefire carried by Iraq's PM; Hormuz status the sticking point). 2 Al Jazeera, "Trump says US may take over Kharg Island," 8 Jul 2026, and CNBC/NBC liveblogs, 22–24 Jul 2026 (interim truce "over"; "we attacked Kharg Island last night"; 13th consecutive night). 3 Yahoo Finance / Fortune, 24 Jul 2026 (Brent ~\$97, ~4% on day, +~38% m/m); TradingEconomics (WTI ~\$87.88). 4 Al Jazeera / CNBC, 8–24 Jul 2026 (Trump, Kharg as leverage). 5 Al Jazeera; PBS NewsHour, 8 Jul 2026 (Mojtaba Khamenei, "the will of our nation"; Hormuz as leverage while Iran keeps exporting). 6 FDD, 22 Jul 2026 (ships reroute pre-emptively); IEA demand downgrades via Seeking Alpha, Jul 2026 (demand-destruction reading).

UKRAINE FINISHES OFF RUSSIA'S REFINERIES

The quieter story of the war ran deep inside Russia. Kyiv's long-range campaign against Russian fuel production is now, by Ukrainian accounting, essentially complete — the last of the country's eleven largest gasoline producers struck this month, after deep-strike drones reached Gazprom Neft's Omsk plant some 2,500 kilometres from the front, the Yaroslavl and Syzran refineries, and the Salavat petrochemical complex in Bashkortostan.¹ Refining-capacity attrition, not territory, is the strategy: a slow squeeze on the fuel and the revenue that keep the war running. It advances the campaign this desk has tracked since spring; the read-through to the oil price (p3, p15) is the part a market watches.

CONGO'S EBOLA SHOWS ITS FIRST CRACKS

The Bundibugyo-strain outbreak declared in eastern Congo on 15 May is now the third-largest on record — 2,423 confirmed cases and 967 deaths by the 19 July count, still the fastest-spreading in its first month — but for the first time the WHO reports "early signs of stabilisation."² Ituri province accounts for over nine in ten cases; the Bundibugyo species complicates treatment, since the approved therapeutics were built for the Zaire strain. The hopeful line runs through Uganda, where the linked cluster has gone quiet since 21 June and the country is counting down the 42 days to an all-clear. The caveat flagged in No. 46 holds: no vaccine is approved for this species specifically.

A US-SAUDI NUCLEAR PACT, SIGNED MID-WAR

The deal-making did not pause for the fighting. On 23 July the US Department of Energy confirmed a commercial civil-nuclear cooperation pact with Saudi Arabia — the scaffolding, Washington says, for a decades-long partnership.³ Trump insists the text bars

Saudi enrichment on its own soil and made it "totally subject" to Riyadh joining the Abraham Accords. Critics are unconvinced on both counts; Senator Ed Markey accused the President of "caving," and analysts note the terms do not obviously forbid enriching third-country fuel. Israel is alarmed regardless — a nuclear-capable neighbour is a nuclear-capable neighbour, whatever the annex says.

967

CONFIRMED DEATHS IN CONGO'S BUNDIBUGYO-STRAIN EBOLA OUTBREAK — 2,423 CASES, THE THIRD-LARGEST ON RECORD, NOW SHOWING THE WHO'S FIRST "EARLY SIGNS OF STABILISATION."

A refinery war, an epidemic turning, a nuclear pact and a rejected truce — the week's business ran on, indifferent to the fires it was written beside.

IN BRIEF

Colombia: In his last presidential address (20 July) Gustavo Petro urged supporters to defend his reforms and again rejected president-elect Abelardo de la Espriella's 21 June run-off win, alleging fraud without evidence — though EU observers praised the vote. His term ends 7 August; he says he will skip the inauguration but hand over peacefully.⁴

Canada: Washington's 50% tariff on most Canadian goods — energy, potash and critical minerals spared — still bites within about thirty days; PM Mark Carney has declined to retaliate, saying only that talks would "deepen and speed up." The market read is on p15.⁵

DOHA

AL JAZEERA FRAMING

Al Jazeera reads the rejected truce as a matter of dignity, not obstinacy: a ceasefire that leaves Hormuz's status open, in this telling, asks Iran to trade a permanent surrender for a temporary quiet. The frame is the region's civilians and the neighbours who did not start the fire — the human cost of a war of choice fought over other people's water — rather than the belligerents' leverage.⁶

BEIJING

CHINESE FRAMING

Beijing keeps to its line — immediate de-escalation, a return to the June framework — paired with unspoken calm about the energy flows on which China leans, since its own tankers keep loading Iranian crude through the contested strait. State media foregrounds the threat to global trade; Western analysts read the same statements as quietly banking the war's side-effects, cheaper oil and a distracted Washington, while paying none of its costs.⁷

SOURCES 1 Moscow Times / Ukrainska Pravda / CNBC, Jul 2026 (Ukraine's campaign against Russia's 11 largest gasoline producers; Omsk ~2,500 km strike 6 Jul; Yaroslavl, Syzran 12 Jul, Salavat 13–14 Jul). 2 UN News / OCHA, Jul 2026 (DR Congo Bundibugyo Ebola: 2,423 cases, 967 deaths as of 19 Jul; third-largest on record; WHO "early signs of stabilisation"; Uganda 42-day countdown). 3 US DoE via NBC News, "Trump signs US-Saudi nuclear deal," 23 Jul 2026; Axios, 23 Jul 2026 (Markey "caving"; enrichment/oversight critics). 4 Washington Post, 20 Jul 2026; NBC News (Petro's last address; rejects de la Espriella's win; term ends 7 Aug). 5 NPR, "Trump imposes 50% tariffs on Canadian goods," 21 Jul 2026 (Carney; ~30-day bite). 6 Al Jazeera, 22–24 Jul 2026 (framing of the rejected ceasefire). 7 Chinese state-media framing via regional coverage, 22–24 Jul 2026; CNBC (China oil imports through Hormuz).

SINGAPORE • TRADE

Washington Files Singapore Under "Forced Labour"

A new 12.5% US tariff on roughly a third of the island's exports took effect on Friday – the fruit of a forced-labour finding Singapore flatly rejects – even as the chips and medicines that are the real engine were spared. What it does, and does not, cost a household.

It is a strange thing to be lectured on labour ethics by a tariff. From one minute past midnight Washington time on Friday, the United States applied a 12.5% duty to roughly a third of Singapore's domestic exports – the outcome of a Section 301 investigation alleging the island failed to police goods made with forced labour somewhere in their supply chains.¹ Because the flat 10% "reciprocal" tariff expired that morning, the shift is from a simple 10% to a split regime – and the split is the mercy. Energy, pharmaceuticals, semiconductors and much electronics are exempt, which shields the AI-and-chip export machine driving the whole economy; the duty falls on the non-electronic third that was already the soft part of the book.

Singapore's answer was unusually blunt for a small state that trades on good manners. The trade ministry said there was "no evidence of Singapore's role in the supply chains of goods associated with forced labour," and that its position was "corroborated by US Department of Labor and US Customs data"; Foreign Minister Vivian Balakrishnan raised it with Secretary of State Marco Rubio on 23 July, restating that the tariff has "no technical or economic basis."² For a reader, the read-through is narrow: this is a levy on someone else's margins, not the supermarket shelf – the exposure is the

exporters in that non-exempt third, where June's non-electronic exports had already *fallen* 2.9%, not consumer prices here. See p15 for the macro tilt.

THE CHATTER

The forums took the framing personally. Lowyat and r/singapore threads read the "forced labour" label as pretextual – a tariff in search of a rationale – with more irritation at the insult than fear of the sum, while r/singaporefi has shifted from 2025's recession-scare to "risks persist, but eased." Directional mood, not a poll.³

THE SCEPTIC

Don't let the exemptions lull you. The duty lands precisely on the segment already contracting – non-electronic exports fell 2.9% in June even as the headline dazzled – so it compounds a soft spot rather than grazing a strong one. And the 5.7% GDP that frames it is a base-effect-plus-semiconductors number: a narrow, borrowed strength is exactly the kind a well-aimed tariff finds.⁴

12.5%

THE NEW US TARIFF ON ~A THIRD OF SINGAPORE'S EXPORTS, FROM A SECTION 301 FORCED-LABOUR FINDING THE ISLAND REJECTS – WITH CHIPS, PHARMA AND ENERGY EXEMPT, SPARING THE EXPORT ENGINE.

TARIFF 12.5%

CHIPS SPARED

"NO BASIS"

THE ECONOMY BEHIND IT

Growth still runs hot, for now: advance Q2 GDP was 5.7% year-on-year (easing from 6.3%), manufacturing up 12.2% on chip demand; June headline inflation was 1.9%, core 1.6%, both inside the 1.5–2.5% band.⁵ **But the wire is cooling:** June's non-oil exports rose 20.7%, half May's pace. The MAS quarterly statement lands Monday 27 July; a hold is consensus (p15).

STILL ON THE WIRE

A younger Cabinet takes the oath Monday – Jeffrey Siow to full Transport and second Finance, David Neo to full minister – with the trade ministry becoming the Ministry of Energy, Trade and Industry from 1 October, energy now an economic axis in its own right (No. 51).⁶ **Changi** is eyeing six underserved routes – Banda Aceh, Da Lat, Almaty, Tashkent among them – ahead of Terminal 5 (p19); and the navy launched its second multi-role combat vessel, *Valour*, on 23 July.

SOURCES ¹ Malay Mail; The Star; Mothership, 24 Jul 2026 (US 12.5% tariff on ~1/3 of Singapore's exports, effective 24 Jul, from a USTR Section 301 forced-labour probe; 53 economies hit; prior 10% reciprocal tariff expired 24 Jul; energy/pharma/semiconductors/certain electronics & aerospace exempt). ² MTI media statement on the Section 301 investigation; Malay Mail, 24 Jul 2026 ("no evidence... corroborated by US DoL and Customs data"; Balakrishnan raised it with Rubio 23 Jul, "no technical or economic basis"). ³ forums.lowyat.net and r/singapore / r/singaporefi threads, Jul 2026 (directional community sentiment, not quantified). ⁴ Enterprise Singapore via Xinhua, 17 Jul 2026 (June non-electronic NODX -2.9%); Vietnamplus / FocusEconomics, Jul 2026 (base-effect and pharma-unwind caveats). ⁵ SingStat / MTI advance estimate, 14 Jul 2026 (Q2 GDP +5.7% y/y, +1.1% q/q; manufacturing +12.2%); AsiaNews Network, ~23 Jul 2026 (June CPI +1.9% headline, +1.6% core). ⁶ PMO, "Changes to Cabinet," 22 Jul 2026; The Star, 14 Jul 2026 (Changi routes); Singapore MINDEF (MRCV *Valour* launched 23 Jul).

PROPERTY • THE QUARTER IN THE BOOKS

The Prime End Inverts the Market

URA's final second-quarter numbers landed on Friday, and the usual order flipped: Core Central and landed homes led while the outer rings fell — even as Turf City's first-ever private condo books today, a live test of whether the school belt still pays up.

The headline was mild and the story underneath it was not. Private home prices rose 0.5% in the second quarter — a seventh straight quarterly gain, but decelerating from 0.9%, for a first-half rise of 1.4%.¹ The interest is in the segments, where the market turned itself inside out. The Core Central Region — prime, the part that had lagged for two years — jumped 2.0%, and landed homes rebounded 2.6%; meanwhile the mass-market rings that usually lead *fell*, the Rest of Central down 1.4% and the Outside Central down 0.1%. Rents firmed 0.7%. For a decade the outer suburbs set the pace and prime followed; this quarter, prime led and the suburbs sagged. That inversion, not the 0.5%, is the read a property owner should take away.

The cooling is clearest in public housing. HDB resale prices slipped 0.3% in the quarter, a second straight decline and the first back-to-back drop in about seven years, as a wave of newly eligible flats and a heavy build-to-order pipeline hand buyers options they lacked a year ago.² Against that soft mass-market floor, today's launch is the live experiment. Dunearn House — 380 units from Frasers Property, CSC Land and Sekisui House, the first private home ever offered on the old Turf City racecourse land — books this afternoon from S\$1.475 million, an indicative S\$2,799 a square foot brushing S\$3,000 at the top, after some 5,900 people came through the

preview.³ A prime, school-belt flag planted the same week the heartland softened.

+2.0%

CORE CENTRAL REGION PRICES IN Q2 — THE LONG-LAGGING PRIME SEGMENT FINALLY LEADING, AS THE REST OF CENTRAL (-1.4%) AND OUTSIDE CENTRAL (-0.1%) RINGS THAT USUALLY SET THE PACE FELL.

THE CHATTER

The forums read a widening gap, not a boom. HardwareZone's "how you view the market now" threads describe resale condo prices as "stagnant at best" while new launches "continue to be priced high" — a new-versus-resale spread that leaves upgraders stuck between a soft flat and a S\$3,000-psf launch. On Dunearn specifically the split is bull-versus-bear on the Nanyang-Hwa Chong premium: a fair first-mover ask, or an unproven hold on new ground.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Don't read the prime bounce as a durable revival. EdgeProp's analysts argue the Core Central lift "may not go the distance" without a loosening of the additional buyer's stamp duty — which the government has signalled it will not grant — so prime stays range-bound, its growth capped to local and PR buyers. On this reading the inversion is structural, a product of policy and land-sale timing, and prime could keep *underperforming* the outer rings on a growth basis through 2027. A record land bid and a shiny launch are not a market.⁵

READ-THROUGH • FOR AN OWNER

The market has split into two speeds and swapped which one leads. If you own **prime or landed**, the tape finally turned your way this quarter (+2.0% / +2.6%). If you hold an **outer-ring condo or an HDB flat**, two straight quarters of resale softening say price to today's market, not last year's momentum — and a heavier launch and build-to-order pipeline is the mechanism pressing on you. Upgraders lose a little leverage; the S\$3,000-psf launch is not the same market as the flat you'd sell to reach it.⁶

STILL ON THE SHELF

Bayshore Drive — the Frasers-led consortium's record S\$2.128 billion bid (S\$1,323 psf ppr), the largest-ever government land sale outside the CBD, is confirmed; ~1,280 homes above the future Bedok South MRT underwrite East Coast pricing years out (No. 51).⁷ **Build-to-order**: no July exercise — the next launch is October (~7,960 flats across Bedok, Geylang, Sembawang, Tengah, Toa Payoh and Yishun), the incoming supply that is itself cooling resale.

SOURCES 1 URA media release pr26-57, 24 Jul 2026 (Q2 private price index +0.5% q/q, 1H +1.4%; CCR +2.0%, RCR -1.4%, OCR -0.1%, landed +2.6%; rents +0.7%); corroborated Yahoo SG / PropNex, 24 Jul 2026. 2 Mothership; PropNex, 1 Jul 2026 (HDB resale index -0.3% q/q to 2027, a 2nd straight decline, first back-to-back in ~7 years). 3 99.co; EdgeProp; Stacked Homes, Jul 2026 (Dunearn House books 25 Jul; from S\$1.475m, -S\$2,799 psf; ~5,900 preview visitors; Frasers/CSC Land/Sekisui House, 380 units). 4 forums.hardwarezone.com.sg "how you view the property market now" thread, Jul 2026 (new-vs-resale gap; directional sentiment). 5 EdgeProp, "CCR came back swinging — can it go the distance?", Jul 2026 (ABSD/structural read). 6 Meridian analysis on the two-speed market. 7 Yahoo Finance SG / The Star, 15 Jul 2026 (Bayshore Drive record S\$2.128bn / \$1,323 psf ppr bid); HDB, "19,600 BTO flats in 2026" (October exercise ~7,960 flats).

TECHNOLOGY • OPEN WEIGHTS

The Biggest Open Model Yet Lands Monday

Moonshot's Kimi K3 — 2.8 trillion parameters, priced at Western parity rather than under it — opens its weights on 27 July, the closest an open model has come to the frontier. The catch is that "open" now means "if you own a cluster."

The open-weight race has a new high-water mark, and it is Chinese. On Monday, Beijing's Moonshot AI publishes the full weights of Kimi K3 — unveiled at Shanghai's World AI Conference on 16 July and live via its own API since — under a modified-MIT licence.¹ The specifications are the largest yet released into the open: 2.8 trillion total parameters in a mixture-of-experts design that fires roughly fifty billion per token, a one-million-token context, and — the detail that unsettles rivals — pricing set deliberately at Western parity (\$3 per million input, \$15 output) rather than the usual undercut. On the independent Artificial Analysis composite it scores 57, third behind only Claude Fable 5 and GPT-5.6, and its makers claim it edges the frontier closed models on front-end coding while running some 40% cheaper — the moment an open model stopped trailing at a respectful distance.

For the reader with a home lab, the asterisk is the whole story, and it is on p8: even at four-bit precision, K3's weights need around 1.4 terabytes of fast memory before a single token of context.² This is not a desktop model or even a single-workstation one; it is a multi-node, server-rack download you admire rather than run. The word "open" has quietly split in two — open-as-in-inspectable, a genuine and valuable thing, and open-as-in-runnable, which for the true frontier now needs the same capital a closed

API was supposed to save you. K3 is emphatically the first kind, and — without a cluster in the garage — resolutely not the second.

2.8T

PARAMETERS IN KIMI K3, THE LARGEST OPEN-WEIGHT MODEL EVER RELEASED — SCORING 3RD ON THE ARTIFICIAL ANALYSIS COMPOSITE, YET NEEDING ~1.4TB OF MEMORY TO RUN EVEN AT 4-BIT.

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA the mood before Monday's drop is equal parts excitement and self-deprecation: engineers are pre-staging inference stacks, while the top comment on every thread is a version of "download it to say you did — nobody's self-hosting 1.4 terabytes at home." The genuine home-lab win is a tier down (p8).³

THE SCEPTIC

Two cautions before the "DeepSeek moment" headlines write themselves. First, Moonshot has trumpeted near-frontier coding scores while not publishing full hallucination or safety data — a near-frontier claim with a gap where the caveats go. Second, the framing is now as much politics as engineering: OpenAI's Dean Ball is publicly calling open Chinese weights a path to "AI communism," so expect the benchmark noise to arrive pre-loaded with FUD in both directions.⁴

KIMI K3

OPEN ≠ RUNNABLE

PARITY PRICING

WASHINGTON

THE CONTROL VIEW

The chip-control machinery grinds on beneath the model news. Nvidia's tightened Asia whitelist has cut more than half its prior buyers, and the diversion case around the Singapore neo-cloud Megaspeed remains live, no new ruling this week.⁵ The bet is unchanged: gate the hardware, and the weights can be as open as they like.

BEIJING

THE OPEN-WEIGHTS VIEW

K3 is the counter-move. If the frontier hardware is fenced off, give the world the frontier software — free, permissively licensed, priced at parity to prove it is not desperate. It is soft power by benchmark: a Chinese model atop an open leaderboard is a fact no export control can revoke.

SOURCES | Cryptobriefing; Interconnects (N. Lambert); Tech, Jul 2026 (Kimi K3 unveiled 16 Jul at WAIC, open weights 27 Jul, modified-MIT; 2.8T total / ~50B active, 1M context; \$3/\$15 per M tokens; Artificial Analysis composite 57, 3rd behind Fable 5 and GPT-5.6). 2 Tech; Simon Willison, 16 Jul 2026 (~1.4TB at 4-bit MXFP4, ~5.6TB at 16-bit before context). 3 r/LocalLLaMA / vLLM & SGLang threads, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). 4 TechTimes, 24 Jul 2026 (undisclosed hallucination risk); taekim substack ("expect a lot of FUD"); Medianama, Jul 2026 (Dean Ball "AI communism" framing). 5 Reuters via KFGO; TechTimes, 13–15 Jul 2026 (Nvidia halves Asia buyer list); Bloomberg / CNBC (Megaspeed probe, no new ruling this week).

WHAT A PROSUMER CAN ACTUALLY SELF-HOST

The useful news sits a tier below Monday's giant (p7). **GLM-5.2** is the community's current best *practical* open coder — 82.7% on Terminal-Bench 2.1, 91.2% GPQA, MIT-licensed — and runs quantised on a single 96GB card; **MiniMax M3** still tops the open rankings on real software tasks (59% on SWE-Bench Pro).¹ For a local voice or assistant brain, **Qwen3 30B-A3B** is the sweet spot, an Unsloth quant clocking about 45 tokens a second on one card. The rule of thumb for the reader's rig is unchanged: a 96GB card holds a ~120B-parameter MoE at four-bit in 60–72GB, or a 70B dense model at eight-bit with headroom — near-full-precision quality without leaving the desk.

CAPACITY IS NOT SPEED — THE BANDWIDTH TRAP

The reader eyeing a 128GB box to hold big sparse models should read the fine print. On a dense model an **RTX 5090** runs near 575 tokens a second; a **DGX Spark** — same headline capacity — manages 25 to 32, because memory bandwidth, not gigabytes, governs generation, and the Spark's 273 GB/s is a fraction of the card's 1,792.² The Spark (\$4,699) and AMD's Strix Halo box (Framework Desktop, ~\$2,350) are fine for *parking* a large model you query occasionally; for single-stream speed a discrete card or an M5 Max — which runs ~229B quantised and roughly quadruples the M4's prompt processing under MLX — still wins. Match the tool to the model, not to the spec-sheet headline.

"Open" now splits in two: open-if-you-own-a-cluster, and the quietly excellent mid-size models that actually fit one card.

575 : 30

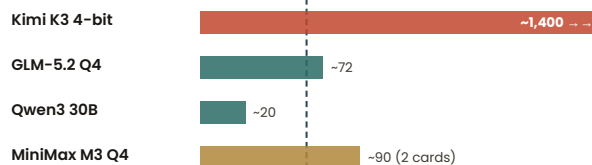
TOKENS A SECOND, RTX 5090 VERSUS DGX SPARK ON A DENSE MODEL — SAME NOMINAL CAPACITY, A 6.6× MEMORY-BANDWIDTH GAP. CAPACITY IS NOT SPEED.

THE CLI GROWS UP

The fortnight's real home-lab upgrade is quieter than any model. **Ollama v0.32.1** turns the CLI itself into an agent — chat, code, web-search and tool-delegation from the terminal, a skills system, unlimited tool rounds and flash-attention on older Nvidia cards.³ Under the

hood, vLLM 0.21 stabilised DeepSeek V4 on Blackwell and llama.cpp merged speculative decoding for the latest Qwen — the unglamorous plumbing that makes a local stack keep pace. The frontier makes the headlines; the runtimes make it usable.

FITS ON ONE 96GB CARD? (approx memory, GB)



Meridian original · quant sizes approximate 96GB card and the line don't fit one card

Monday's giant overshoots a single card twentyfold even at four-bit; the models you actually deploy sit under the line.

THE CHATTER

On r/LocalLLaMA the Apache- and MIT-licensed flood is cheered, with two recurring gripes: the headline giants aren't on the routers yet, so real testing is hard, and "runs on a workstation" is marketing when the accessible quant is 1.4 terabytes. Ollama's turn to an agentic CLI, meanwhile, revived the long-running "credit and keep pace with llama.cpp" grievance — but GLM-5.2 still draws the most *earned* praise as the one people actually deploy.⁴

THE SCEPTIC

Not every number this fortnight was shown. Alibaba previewed **Qwen3.8-Max** at WAIC on 19 July, claiming 2.4 trillion parameters and a spot "second only to Fable 5" — with no benchmark table, no model card, no licence and no weights date. A ranking asserted is not a ranking earned; treat it as vapour until the artefacts appear. The lesson generalises to Monday's K3 too: wait for the independent runs, not the launch slide.⁵

IN BRIEF · THE CLOCK RAN OUT

DeepSeek's legacy API is gone. The *deepseek-chat* and *deepseek-reasoner* names stopped resolving at 15:59 UTC on 24 July, exactly as scheduled (graded on p2); if an agent or a Home-Assistant hook broke this weekend, point it at *deepseek-v4-flash* or *-v4-pro* — a one-line change, same base URL and key.⁶

Kimi K3's weights open Monday (p7) — admire it, don't try to host it. **The DeepSeek-proxy rumour stays false:** no evidence V4 routes to a closed model. Check the changelog, not the timeline.

SOURCES 1 BenchLM / Spectrum AI Lab open-weight rankings, Jul 2026 (GLM-5.2: 82.7% Terminal-Bench 2.1, GPQA 91.2%, MIT; MiniMax M3 59% SWE-Bench Pro); localllm.in (Qwen3 30B-A3B ~45 tok/s). 2 Float16 / Compute-Market benchmarks, Jul 2026 (RTX 5090 ~575 tok/s vLLM AWQ-INT4 vs DGX Spark ~25–32; 1,792 vs 273 GB/s; Spark \$4,699, Strix Halo Framework Desktop ~\$2,350); aiproductivity (M5 Max ~229B quantised, ~4× M4 prompt processing under MLX). 3 Local AI Master / Releasebot, 16 Jul 2026 (Ollama v0.32.1 agent mode, skills, flash-attention); Codersera (vLLM 0.21 DeepSeek V4 on Blackwell; llama.cpp MTP). 4 r/LocalLLaMA and Hacker News discussion, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). 5 TechTimes / MarkTechPost, 19–21 Jul 2026 (Qwen3.8-Max preview, no card/benchmarks/weights). 6 DigitalApplied / Developers Digest DeepSeek migration guides, Jul 2026 (cutover 15:59 UTC 24 Jul).

THE KIT • WEARABLES

Garmin's Answer to Whoop Has No Screen — and No Fee

The CIRQA, on sale this week at US\$199, is a screenless recovery-and-sleep band that aims straight at Whoop's business model: all your data in the app, no annual subscription. Whether it undercuts its own launch is the open question.

Garmin has finally built the thing Whoop owners have been asking a rival to build for years: a screenless band that tracks sleep, recovery and readiness — and then hands you the data without an annual toll. Announced on 21 July and on sale on the 24th, the **CIRQA** costs US\$199.99, carries Garmin's Gen 4 optical heart-rate sensor and a skin-temperature reading, and — the pointed part — puts the full picture in the free Garmin Connect app with no mandatory fee.¹ For a reader who has weighed a Whoop against an Oura, that is the whole pitch in a sentence: the recovery-band concept, minus the subscription that has always been its catch.

The launch then walked into its own feet. Garmin first gated the *live* heart-rate number behind its Connect+ paywall — a subscription tax on a screenless heart-rate band — before partially backtracking after the pushback, and reviewers were quick to note the sensor is Garmin's older Gen 4, paired with an ageing app.² Then there is the size: the5krunner measured the module at 47mm long, about 35% longer than a Whoop and covering half again as much skin, and filed a one-line verdict — "Simply Too Big." The idea is exactly right; the first

execution is a beta wearing a launch date. Worth watching, not yet worth buying.

THE CHATTER

The wearables press — DC Rainmaker and the5krunner's hands-ons — dominates the conversation, and it is split down the middle: relief that someone finally built a fee-free recovery band, against real irritation at the paywall-then-backtrack and the bulk. "The right product, shipped 20% too big and one bad decision too greedy," runs the consensus.³

THE SCEPTIC

The no-fee headline hides an old-parts body. A Gen 4 sensor is two generations behind Garmin's own best, and "no subscription" competes with Whoop's model but not with a working Oura Ring 3 already on your finger for free. The live-HR-behind-a-paywall misstep also tells you where Garmin's instincts pointed first. For an Oura-and-Whoop reader, this is a first-generation product to let mature — not a reason to switch mid-cycle.

\$199

THE GARMIN CIRQA — A SCREENLESS, SUBSCRIPTION-FREE RECOVERY BAND AIMED AT WHOOP'S MODEL, UNDERCUT ON LAUNCH BY A PAYWALLED LIVE-HR READING AND A 47MM MODULE.

CIRQA

NO FEE

SCREENLESS

THE CAMERA THAT SHOOTS EVERYTHING

Sony's FX5 (announced 22 July) is the more exciting object for anyone who shoots. It slots a newly-developed full-frame stacked sensor between the FX3 and the FX6, and is the first Cinema Line body with **Open Gate** — one take that reframes to vertical, square or wide — and **internal X-OCN RAW**, up to 5K/60 and 4K/120, no external recorder.⁴ Price is not yet set (expect north of the FX3). A body that dissolves the FX3-versus-full-rig dilemma — hold for the price and the independent thermal tests.

ALSO ON THE BENCH

Samsung's Galaxy Glasses broke cover at Unpacked in London on 22 July: an Android-XR, Gemini-powered pair that is deliberately *audio-first* — no in-lens display, a 12MP camera, directional speakers, photochromic lenses, about 50 grams.⁵ It joins Google's own audio-first glasses (shipping this autumn) and undercuts Snap's display-toting Specs on both weight and price. The reveal is intent, not a ship date. Premium audio had no new-peg launch this week — the picks hold, carried not re-argued.

SOURCES 1 Smartwatch Insight; Forbes; DC Rainmaker hands-on, 21–22 Jul 2026 (Garmin CIRQA announced 21 Jul, on sale 24 Jul, US\$199.99, screenless, subscription-free, Gen 4 Elevate sensor + skin temperature). 2 Gadgets & Wearables; Android Police, 22 Jul 2026 (live-HR behind Connect+, partial backtrack; ageing sensor/app value gap); the5krunner, 24 Jul 2026 ("Simply Too Big" — 47mm, ~35% longer than Whoop). 3 DC Rainmaker / the5krunner hands-ons, Jul 2026 (wearables-press reaction characterised). 4 Sony EU press centre; ProVideo Coalition, 22 Jul 2026 (FX5: new full-frame stacked sensor, 15+ stops, first FX Open Gate + internal X-OCN RAW, 5K/60 & 4K/120; price TBA). 5 Gadget Hacks; Glass Almanac, 22 Jul 2026 (Samsung Galaxy Glasses: Android XR + Gemini, audio-first, 12MP, ~50g).

THE CONNECTED HOME · THE WEEKEND HOUSE

The House That Knows It's Saturday

Not another gadget this week, but a weekend-morning argument for the local-first setup — where the blinds, the lights and the coffee follow the day with no cloud in the loop — and the cheapest week yet to finish leaving Lutron.

A well-built smart home is loudest on a weekday and invisible on a Saturday, which is when you notice it most. The blinds lift a little later; the kitchen warms before anyone is up; the harsh overhead scene the weekdays need never fires, because the house has been told, quietly, that this is a slow morning. None of it touches a server in Virginia. That is the reader's own architecture — Lutron keypads and shades, a Home Assistant brain, everything decided on the local network — and its virtue is exactly that it keeps working when the internet, or a vendor, does not. On a weekend, when nobody wants to debug anything, the local-first house is the one that simply behaves.

This is also, as it happens, the cheapest week yet to finish the migration off Lutron's own cloud. Home Assistant's July release let you describe an automation in plain intent — "motion detected outside," then point it at an *area* rather than a named sensor — and added **first** / **each** / **all** reaction modes that map cleanly onto a group of Lutron shades or keypad buttons, so a weekend scene is now an afternoon of describing what each room should do, not an evening of YAML.¹ The path is well-worn: the Caséta Smart Bridge PRO exposes dimmers, Pico

remotes and occupancy over Telnet, and you move scenes a room at a time rather than all at once.² On Matter, the standing position holds — the reader doesn't run it, and the July server rewrite is housekeeping, not a reason to.

THE CHATTER

On r/homeassistant the intent-based editor is cheered as "the biggest automation update yet" — closing the gap between knowing what you want and knowing which entity to name. The migrator's thread is the practical one: pair the new editor with the Caséta Pro bridge and convert scenes room by room, keeping the Lutron reliability the household actually chose it for.³

THE SCEPTIC

The abstraction cuts both ways. "Pick an area and let it figure out which sensor" hides *which* sensor fired, and power users warn area triggers misfire in dense multi-sensor rooms and are harder to debug than an explicit entity — a bad trade for a household that wants deterministic lighting above all. And the same release's Matter backend was rewritten wholesale; beta users hit device drop-outs and a firmware-update bug — pure added surface area for a home that doesn't run Matter at all.⁴

LOCAL-FIRST

LUTRON → HA

WEEKEND HOUSE

THE LOCAL VOICE BRAIN

A fully-local Assist stack is now a real cloud-assistant replacement: Whisper for speech-to-text over Wyoming, Home Assistant Assist, and a small model — the Qwen3 family is the community's pick — served from Ollama, with two-to-four-second replies on a GPU.⁵ The reader's own inference box (p8) can host the whole voice brain locally, no cloud in the loop — the same principle as the lights, applied to the microphone.

STILL ON THE SHELF

UniFi Access is a native Home Assistant integration for a Ubiquiti household consolidating door control into one dashboard.⁶ **Next release:** Home Assistant 2026.8 is due around 5 August; no need to chase the beta over a weekend. Carried, not re-argued — the migration is a project measured in rooms, not a single switch-over.

SOURCES 1 home-assistant.io blog, "2026.7," 1 Jul 2026 (intent-based triggers graduate from Labs; first/each/all reaction modes; IR/RF section; Dropbox backup). 2 GitHub, upsert/lutron-caseta-pro (Caséta Smart Bridge PRO / RA2 Select over Telnet — dimmers, Pico remotes, occupancy). 3 r/homeassistant, Jul 2026 (chatter characterised from community context). 4 GitHub home-assistant/core issue #172675 (matter.js OTA update-entity regression); Matter Alpha, 2026 (migration connectivity drops) — single-source-ish, flagged. 5 Local-voice guides (Whisper + Wyoming + Assist + Ollama; Qwen3), 2026. 6 home-assistant.io, UniFi Access integration (added 2026.4).

THE GOOD LIFE · THE WATCH MARKET

The Index Keeps Rising, and Rolex Keeps Slipping

Four straight quarters of gains on the broad watch index — and yet the one name everyone owns is easing at the top. July's read is of a market rising and cooling at once, depending entirely on which watch you happen to hold.

There is a tidy contradiction in the July watch numbers, and it rewards a slow Saturday's attention. WatchCharts' latest index has the overall secondary market up 1.5% — a fourth consecutive quarter above one per cent, the steadiest run since the 2022 peak burst — with Patek Philippe up 2.2% and Audemars Piguet 1.5%.¹ And yet Rolex, the name that anchors most collections, actually slipped about one per cent across May and June as dealer listings hit record highs; the freshly discontinued "Pepsi" GMT-Master II, having jumped 12% early in the year, has drifted back toward US\$22,500 as the supply of sellers swelled. A rising index and a softening blue-chip at once is not a paradox — it is what a maturing market looks like.

The read-through for a reader who buys the odd serious piece is the same one the auction rooms told in July, when Phillips posted the best watch half ever recorded: strength, but concentrated. The money is stacked in trophies — independents, steel Patek, the hyped references — while the broad fleet moves at sensible prices, and the discontinued-model pop is now met by more sellers cashing in than buyers chasing. If there is an object to seek this season it is in Tokyo, where the soft yen (p15) still bends the maths: Grand Seiko's steel "Iwao Blue" Spring Drive (SBGY043, 38.5mm, US\$9,800) is the connoisseur's

buy, the platinum "Waterfall" (SBGZ011, US\$84,000, boutique-only) the dream one.²

+1.5%

THE BROAD WATCH INDEX IN JULY — A FOURTH STRAIGHT QUARTER OF GAINS, EVEN AS ROLEX'S SECONDARY PRICES SLIPPED ~1% ON RECORD DEALER LISTINGS. A MARKET RISING AND COOLING AT ONCE.

THE CHATTER

On WatchCrunch and the forums the mood is part relief, part fatigue: the market declared dead in 2024 is plainly alive, but collectors are visibly tired of big-brand hype and leaning toward character and value — micro-brand GMTs and affordable divers (Vaer, Tissot's Seastar) over another waitlist. "A rising tide for the trophies, not the fleet," as one thread put it, "so buy the watch, not the ticker."³

THE SCEPTIC

The "watch as investment" thesis is being challenged in its own church. Screwdowncrown argues the speculative bubble already ran a full cycle in about 36 months, with broad secondary values well off the 2022 peak (the Subdial 50 down roughly 18% over a trailing year), and Art & Object notes watches are now *cannibalising* fine-art sales — a rotation of the same luxury money, not fresh demand.⁴ Buy the watch because you want to wear it. The spreadsheet is a poor reason.

WATCHCHARTS

ROLEX EASES

TROPHY BID

ON THE BENCH

Vaer's G2 Fairway GMT (US\$449, a run of 300) is the week's charming oddity — a US-assembled Swiss-quartz GMT whose 24-click bezel doubles as a golf score-tracker.⁵ **Panerai's Luminor Luna Rossa** pair (~€11,100–11,200) rides the America's Cup. Audio had no new-peg launch: the Sennheiser Momentum 5 and Sony's tenth-anniversary 1000X "ColleXion" hold as the picks, carried not re-argued.

THE WEAK-YEN ESCAPE

The soft yen (p15) keeps Japan a value play at the top of the market, and the 2026 luxury-hotel pipeline has caught up: **1 Hotel Tokyo** (a biophilic build with sound baths) and the **Waldorf Astoria Osaka** anchor a wave pushing beyond the Tokyo-Kyoto-Osaka triangle.⁶ A note for the autumn trip the Diary is building (p23): the FX read that flatters the shopping flatters the suites too.

SOURCES 1 WatchCharts, "July 2026 Watch Market Update" (overall index +1.5%, 4th straight quarter >+1%; Patek +2.2%, AP +1.5%, Rolex +1.0% but secondary ~-1% May–Jun on record listings; discontinued "Pepsi" GMT ~US\$22,500). 2 Luxury Bazaar Watches & Wonders recap, Jul 2026 (Grand Seiko SBGZ011 "Waterfall" US\$84,000 boutique-only; SBGY043 "Iwao Blue" Spring Drive, 38.5mm, US\$9,800). 3 WatchCrunch / Worn & Wound, Jul 2026 (community mood characterised; value/micro-brand lean). 4 screwdowncrown, "Luxury asset watch correction," 2025–26 (Subdial 50 ~-18% trailing year); Art & Object, Jul 2026 (watches cannibalising art sales). 5 GearJunkie / Fratello, 22–23 Jul 2026 (Vaer G2 Fairway GMT, US\$449, run of 300); Monochrome (Panerai Luminor Luna Rossa PAM01768 / PAM01791). 6 Forbes Travel Guide, May 2026 (1 Hotel Tokyo); Hospitality Design, 2026 Japan hotel pipeline (Waldorf Astoria Osaka).

SCREEN & SOUND · THE BOX OFFICE

Nolan Fills the Cinema, and the Theatre Finds a Pulse

The Odyssey opened to the biggest launch of his career and a 95% score; a week later *Spider-Man* opens here on Thursday to record presales. Two proofs in a fortnight that the big-screen event still pulls a crowd off the sofa.

Christopher Nolan has made a three-hour, 70mm, largely un-spoilable Homer adaptation the biggest opening of his career — which is either an act of faith in the audience or a very expensive dare, and it paid. *The Odyssey* launched to US\$123.5 million at home and US\$263.7 million worldwide, Nolan's largest global debut ever, then posted the best Monday of 2026 at US\$18.6 million; the critics returned 95% and audiences an even warmer 97%, the highest marks of his career.¹ For this reader it is the film of the summer on paper — myth, scale, format obsession, a director who still believes the cinema is a place you go — and the receipts say a great many people agree.

The sequel to that argument opens here on Thursday. *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* — Tom Holland and Zendaya, Destin Daniel Cretton directing — reaches Singapore screens on 30 July (a day ahead of the US), on record advance sales, with trackers that have climbed from an already-large US\$180 million toward US\$230–250 million and

beyond.² Hold those as projections, not receipts. But a prestige Greek epic and a tentpole *Spider-Man* in successive weekends is the closest 2026 has come to an argument that the theatrical event has a pulse again — one film for the crowd that queues at 7am for 70mm, one for everyone else.

\$263.7m

THE ODYSSEY'S WORLDWIDE OPENING — THE BIGGEST OF NOLAN'S CAREER — AT 95% ON THE CRITICS' METER AND 97% WITH AUDIENCES. A THREE-HOUR HOMER ADAPTATION, AND THE THEATRE SHOWED UP.

THE CHATTER

On r/movies the *Odyssey* talk was about access as much as art — cinephiles queuing for 2am and 7am screenings, seats at the handful of true 70mm-IMAX houses reselling at a premium — while the *Spider-Man* threads argue whether Cretton's grounded, street-level Peter can hold the older crowd Nolan just proved still turns out. The final trailer drew millions of views in hours, most of them praising a Raimi-era return.³

THE ODYSSEY

SPIDER · THU

THEATRE'S BACK?

ON THE TURNTABLE

A heavy New Music Friday (24 July) landed some two dozen records; the reliably-dated drops include new work from **Charli xcx**, **The Strokes**, **Shania Twain**, **Tyla** and **The Hu**.⁴ A caution on the rumour mill: specific album titles circulating for several of these were not confirmed by their labels at press, so treat the artists as solid and the tracklists as speculation.

FOR THE CULTURE TRAVELLER

Busan International Film Festival (Asia's largest, running into October) pairs naturally with the autumn-foliage swing the Diary is mapping (p23) and the Seoul deep dive (p21) — a Korea-then-Japan cultural itinerary for a reader who plans trips around what is worth seeing on a screen. Closer to home, **Massive Attack** play The Star Theatre on 29 July, a strong late-week pick.

THE SCEPTIC

Keep the *Spider-Man* numbers in their box. Pre-release tracking has a long history of running hot into a big opening and quietly resetting once the actuals land, and MovieWeb rightly notes that *No Way Home*'s once-in-a-generation three-*Spider-Man* hook is not one *Brand New Day* can replicate. Presales measure the die-hards who were always going opening night, not the casual audience that decides week two. The proven data point this fortnight is *The Odyssey*'s receipts; the *Spider* figure is still a forecast wearing a headline's clothes.⁵

SOURCES 1 Forbes, 21 Jul 2026 (*The Odyssey* best Monday of 2026, \$18.6m); Variety, Jul 2026 (\$123.5m domestic / \$263.7m worldwide opening — Nolan's biggest global debut; RT 95% critics / 97% audience). 2 Deadline; Box Office Pro / ScreenRant, Jul 2026 (*Spider-Man* tracking \$180m – \$230–250m+); Shaw Theatres / TheDirect (Singapore release 30 Jul). 3 r/movies discussion; Yahoo Entertainment, Jul 2026 (trailer reaction; characterised from coverage). 4 Exclaim! New Music Friday masterlist, 24 Jul 2026 (Charli xcx, The Strokes, Shania Twain, Tyla, The Hu; titles unconfirmed). 5 MovieWeb, "Spider-Man: Brand New Day box office tracking," Jul 2026 (tracking-runs-hot caution; *No Way Home* hook not replicable).

THE FAMILY DESK • THE EVIDENCE

The Rulebook Stopped Counting Hours

America's paediatricians retired the decade-old "limit the hours" advice for a harder set of questions — is the screen any good, is it displacing sleep and movement, can she stop? For a parent of an eleven-year-old, it points the worry somewhere far more useful.

For ten years the standing advice to parents was a number: cap the daily hours and you have done your job. This year the American Academy of Pediatrics quietly retired that framework. Its new policy statement, *Digital Ecosystems, Children, and Adolescents*, drops the hourly-limits model in favour of three questions a parent can actually answer: is the content high-quality and age-appropriate; is it interactive or passive; and is it displacing sleep, movement or real-world connection?¹ The practical translation for an eleven-year-old is liberating. A co-watched documentary and an hour of an algorithmic feed are not the same "hour," and never were; the AAP has finally stopped pretending they are. Judge the screen by what it *replaces*, not by the clock beside it.

The evidence has been drifting this way for a while, toward "nuanced" rather than "harmful." A 2026 study out of the University of Adelaide found a wellbeing *sweet spot* — moderate social-media use, up to around twelve-and-a-half hours a week, associated with *better* wellbeing than either heavy use or none at all — and the Cambridge psychologist Amy Orben's standing caution is that most of this evidence is correlational: children may go online *because* they are already struggling, not the other way round.² "Nuanced," though, is not "harmless." A decade-long Melbourne study of some 1,200 young people still

found two-plus hours a day tied to a small but real rise in depression a year later. The honest position is neither panic nor a shrug: watch the quality, protect the sleep, and keep talking.

A co-watched documentary and an hour of an algorithmic feed were never the same "hour." The paediatricians have finally stopped pretending they are.

~12.5 h

A WEEK — THE SOCIAL-MEDIA "SWEET SPOT" A 2026 UNIVERSITY OF ADELAIDE STUDY LINKS TO *BETTER* WELLBEING THAN HEAVY USE OR NONE AT ALL. THE DOSE, NOT THE MERE PRESENCE, IS THE THING.

THE CHATTER

On r/ScienceBasedParenting the practical consensus is unusually settled: watch for the tells of compulsion — distress when the device is taken, sneaking it, lost sleep — rather than policing a nightly hour count; delay the algorithmic feed while a call-and-text phone covers reachability; and, the part parents resist, apply the same rules to the adult in the house. A child models the phone habit she sees more than the one she is told.³

QUALITY > HOURS

THE SWEET SPOT

AGES 11–12

THE CHEAP WIN IS SLEEP

The clearest lever in the whole field is bedtime. National Sleep Foundation data this year found nearly **44% of US children** do not get enough sleep, and related work ties leaving a phone ringer on overnight to a ~25% higher risk of sleep disturbance in eleven-to-twelve-year-olds.⁴ Much of the apparent "screen harm" in the literature runs through lost sleep. The fix is unglamorous and free: the phone charges outside the bedroom.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

The playbook for an eleven-year-old is duller than the headlines: **judge the screen by what it replaces**, not the clock. **Delay the social feed, not the phone. Protect sleep and movement.** And **keep asking** — the new worry (p14) is invisible unless you talk. Singapore's "Screen Smart from the Start" portal puts an eleven-year-old in the 7–12 band and favours co-viewing over a ban. General guidance, not medical advice.⁵

SOURCES 1 American Academy of Pediatrics, policy statement "Digital Ecosystems, Children, and Adolescents," Jan 2026 (retires hourly-limits framework for a quality/displacement model); AAP News; CHOC explainer. 2 University of Adelaide, 2026 (JAMA-published; social-media wellbeing "sweet spot" ~up to 12.5 h/week); Psychology Today, Jun 2026 (Amy Orben, correlational-evidence caution); Murdoch Children's Research Institute, 2026 (≥2 h/day tied to a small rise in depression a year later). 3 r/ScienceBasedParenting, Jul 2026 (characterised from community context). 4 National Sleep Foundation via PR Newswire, Mar 2026 (~44% of US children under-sleep); HealthDay, 2026 (overnight phone ringer / tween sleep disturbance). 5 MDDI, "Screen Smart from the Start," bescreensmart.gov.sg (7–12 age band). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE NEW WORRY ISN'T THE FEED — IT'S THE COMPANION

The fastest-moving thing in a tween's digital life is no longer the social feed but the chatbot that talks back. Common Sense Media reports that 72% of teenagers have now tried an AI companion and 52% use one regularly, with Character.AI — twenty-million-plus monthly users, many of them minors — the biggest.¹ US regulators warned this year about emotionally manipulative design and the displacement of real relationships, and a proposed SAFE BOTs Act would force AI-disclosure and break prompts. None of that reaches an eleven-year-old at home. What does is a single question, asked without alarm: who — or what — do you talk to when you're bored, or sad? The point is not to ban the thing but to make sure the household, not a chatbot, is the first place a low mood gets taken.

HORMONES, NOT BRA SIZE

One July study is worth flagging precisely because it cuts against the visible-development panic. Researchers at the University of Georgia reported that in girls aged ten to twelve, rising *testosterone* predicted emotional difficulties better than outward physical development did — the internal chemistry of puberty, not how grown-up a child looks, tracking the mood.² Treat it gently: it is single-outlet coverage of one study, and the effect sizes want verifying. But the direction is a useful corrective for a parent watching a daughter change — the thing to attend to is how she *feels*, not how old she suddenly appears.

72%

OF TEENAGERS HAVE TRIED AN AI COMPANION, 52% USING ONE REGULARLY (COMMON SENSE MEDIA) — THE NEWER, QUIETER WORRY THAT A FEED-FOCUSED PARENT MAY MISS ENTIRELY.

SINGAPORE DREW THE LINE AT SCHOOL

The norm your daughter will inherit is already being set. From January this year Singapore's Ministry of Education bars smartphones and smartwatches for the *whole* secondary-school day — recess, co-curriculars and remedial included, not just lessons — and government-issued devices now lock at 10.30pm, paired with Cyber Wellness lessons.³ A parent-and-student petition to relax it for upper-secondary is circulating, so

the mood is mixed rather than settled. She is primary-age today; the point is that the rules she meets next year lean, like the AAP's, toward protecting sleep and attention over counting minutes — and a household that has already practised that will find the transition easy.

The thing to attend to is how she feels, not how grown-up she suddenly appears — and who she talks to when the household isn't looking.

DON'T BE ALARMIST

The scariest single numbers in this field come from surveys that cannot separate cause from effect: an anxious child may reach for a screen — or a chatbot — as much as either makes her anxious. Candice Odgers of UC Irvine puts it plainly: there is "a massive gap between the story parents are told about screens and what the evidence actually tells us," and wildly different activities get "collapsed into a single moral-panic category." Hold the boring fundamentals; treat frightening figures as prompts to check in, not verdicts to act on in fear.⁴

THE CHATTER

The r/ScienceBasedParenting consensus is practical: a call-and-text device or a locked-down phone through the tween years, social platforms and AI companions delayed to the mid-teens, and the same rules applied to the adult in the house. The recurring line on the companion worry is to keep the relationship warm enough that the child brings the low mood to a parent before a bot.⁵

THE SINGAPORE LINE

Singapore has deliberately *not* reached for a blanket ban at home. The MDDI's "Screen Smart from the Start" movement runs on co-viewing, boundaries and offline time, with age-banded guidance that puts an eleven-year-old in the 7–12 tier.⁶ The bet is that a talking, modelling household beats a legislated gate — and the school-day rule above is the one place the state does draw a hard line, precisely because school is where attention is the whole point.

SOURCES 1 Common Sense Media, 2026 (72% of teens have tried an AI companion, 52% use regularly; Character.AI 20M+ monthly users); Social Media Victims Law Center; WKNO/NPR, May 2026 (regulator warnings; proposed SAFE BOTs Act). 2 University of Georgia via MedicalXpress, Jul 2026 (*Psychoneuroendocrinology*; rising testosterone vs visible development in girls 10–12 — single-outlet secondary coverage, effect sizes to be verified). 3 MOE press release, 30 Nov 2025; Mothership, Nov 2025 (smartphones/smartwatches barred the whole secondary-school day from Jan 2026; govt devices lock 10.30pm); Change.org petition, 2026 (relaxation push — self-selected, mood not data). 4 Psychology Today, Jun 2026; C. Odgers (UC Irvine), developingadolescent.semel.ucla.edu (correlational-evidence caution). 5 r/ScienceBasedParenting, Jul 2026 (characterised from community context). 6 MDDI, "Screen Smart from the Start," bescreensmart.gov.sg (7–12 age band). General guidance, not medical advice.

THE MACRO DESK

The barrel eases, but the Fed's question stays "hike?"

Oil round-tripped through a hundred dollars and came back — yet a month of it has done the damage: yields ran to fresh highs, the dollar firmed, equities had their worst day in a month, and gold took the crown. The FOMC and the MAS statement both land next week. Market explanation and education, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

VWRA ~\$188.7 ▼	GLOBAL BONDS (AGGU) ~\$5.82 ▼	US 10Y 4.71% ▲	DX ~101.4 ▲	USD/SGD 1.291	BRENT ~\$97 ▼	GOLD ~\$4,070 ▲	BTC ~\$64.3k ▼
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Start with the barrel, because everything else hangs off it. Brent punched back above US\$100 midweek when Kharg was struck (p3), then gave back about four per cent on Friday to roughly US\$97 — but it is still up something like 38 per cent on the month, and that monthly figure is the one the central banks see.¹ A month of hundred-dollar-ish oil is an inflation shock wherever you sit, and it has turned the Fed's live question from "when do we cut?" into "do we hike?" The daily pullback is welcome; the regime it leaves behind is risk-off, dollar-bid and higher-for-longer.

That is the pivot, and the timing is acute. Into the 28–29 July FOMC — the first under the new chair, Kevin Warsh — CME FedWatch prices roughly a 63% hold against a 36% hike, with rate-cut odds essentially zero.² Singapore's own call lands the same Monday: with June core inflation a mild 1.6%, a hold is the consensus at the MAS statement (12 of 16 economists). Both were still ahead as this issue closed — treat every point estimate as a forecast.

A month of hundred-dollar oil turned the Fed's live question from when to cut into whether to hike. The daily dip doesn't change the regime.

The mechanics ran straight down the board. The 10-year yield pushed to a fresh high near 4.71% and the dollar firmed around 101.4; USD/SGD held near 1.291 — a firm Singapore dollar still flattering the autumn-Japan arithmetic on p23 — while Friday was the S&P 500's worst session in a month and Asia-Pacific shares fell

SOURCES ¹ Yahoo Finance / Fortune, 24 Jul 2026 (Brent ~\$97, --4% on day, +-38% m/m; WTI ~\$88). ² CME FedWatch via CoinGape, 23–24 Jul 2026 (~63% hold vs ~36% hike into 28–29 Jul FOMC, cut odds ~0; Chair Kevin Warsh); Reuters MAS poll via InvestingLive (12 of 16 expect a hold at the 27 Jul statement; June core 1.6%). ³ TradingEconomics, 24 Jul (US 10Y 4.71%; DX ~101.3–101.5); MTFX (USD/SGD ~1.291). ⁴ iShares / eToro (AGGU NAV ~US\$5.82, 20 Jul); investing.com (VWRA ~188.68, 23 Jul — Friday close held). ⁵ Forbes / TradingView, 24 Jul (gold ~\$4,070 spot); Yahoo Finance, 24 Jul (BTC ~\$64.3k, retreated on higher UST yields). ⁶ Yahoo Finance (analyst H2 "meltdown" odds ~35%); Seeking Alpha (oil-as-demand-destruction reading); Boston Fed, "Reassessing the US economy's vulnerability to oil shocks," 2026 (over-tightening risk). Market explanation, not investment advice; forecasts flagged as forecasts.

about 2.2%, "stagflation" creeping back into the strategy notes.³

VWRA, the reader's core, gave ground with global equities — a pullback with the risk on the calendar, not a break; **global bonds** (AGGU near US\$5.82) are the pressured leg, price pain now for yield later, with equity and duration falling together and diversification doing less than it should.⁴ **Gold** is the regime's clear winner, bid to around US\$4,070; **bitcoin** is the tell, soft near US\$64,300 and sold with yields rather than hedging them — read for sensitivity, not endorsed, and note its far higher volatility.⁵

WHAT IT MEANS FOR VWRA, GLOBAL BONDS, GOLD & BTC

A higher-for-longer regime with a month-old oil shock bolted on and a Fed that has stopped talking about cuts — the live risk is now a hike. VWRA's pullback is orderly; global bonds take price pain now for yield later, diversification muted while equities and duration fall together; gold is doing its job as the regime hedge; bitcoin is the most liquidity-sensitive of the four, read for sensitivity, not endorsed. None of this is advice — the two the reader holds are VWRA and global bonds; gold and BTC are read, not recommended.

THE SCEPTIC

Two contrarian trades sit against the consensus. The **stagflation bears** — one veteran now puts H2 "meltdown" odds at 35% — say the oil bid tips a soft economy over. The opposite take reads Friday's oil fall as demand destruction, not relief, and warns the real error may be central banks over-tightening into a supply shock — the priced hikes, not the oil, the mistake.⁶

RISK-OFF

HIKE RISK

DOLLAR BID

CURIOSITIES • ARCHAEOLOGY

A Line of Homer, Folded Into a Mummy

A fragment of the Iliad's "Catalogue of Ships" was found placed on the abdomen of a Roman-era Egyptian mummy some 1,600 years ago — the poem, if the reading holds, sent into the afterlife alongside the dead.

Here is a fact built for a slow Saturday and a dinner table both. Archaeologists working the vast burial grounds of Oxyrhynchus in Egypt reported this month that they had recovered a scrap of papyrus carrying lines from the *Iliad* — specifically the "Catalogue of Ships," Homer's great roll-call of the Greek fleet — laid on the abdomen of a mummified body roughly sixteen centuries old.¹ The image is almost too good: a copy of the founding poem of Western literature, folded against a corpse and wrapped for eternity, a line of Homer accompanying an anonymous Roman-Egyptian into whatever came next. Hold it lightly, though — this is one research team's find, newly announced, and "placed for the afterlife" is their interpretation; the fragment could as easily be recycled scrap, since embalmers routinely reused old papyrus as packing.

Either reading is a marvel, because of *where* it was found. Oxyrhynchus is the single richest source of ancient literature ever excavated — its rubbish heaps and cemeteries have yielded more classical papyri than anywhere on Earth, a great deal of what survives of Greek writing pulled from the town's discarded paper. Whether this scrap was a devotion or a wrapping, it is one more line rescued from the same improbable place: a body that carried, into the

ground, a piece of the poem the living had not yet finished arguing about.

A copy of the founding poem of Western literature, folded against a corpse and wrapped for eternity — devotion, or an embalmer's scrap paper. Either way, a marvel.

~1,600

YEARS SINCE A FRAGMENT OF HOMER'S *ILIAD* WAS PLACED ON THE ABDOMEN OF A MUMMY AT OXYRHYNCHUS — THE RICHEST SOURCE OF ANCIENT LITERATURE EVER EXCAVATED.

THE CHATTER

Among the classics-and-science crowd the find is catnip, and the argument is exactly the right one: is this piety — the poem as a companion for the dead — or is it just what was to hand, an old sheet of the world's most-copied text repurposed as packing? The honest, deflating consensus leans to the latter, and the honest answer is that both possibilities are wonderful, and only more of the Oxyrhynchus hoard will settle it.²

OXYRHYNCHUS

THE ILIAD

TOO NEW TO CALL

A T. REX TOOTH, STILL IN ITS PREY

The second-best fact of the fortnight is 66 million years old and violent: a tyrannosaur tooth crown lodged in the nasal bone of an *Edmontosaurus* skull from Montana's Hell Creek, with no sign of healing — a predator's tooth left in a duck-billed dinosaur's face at the moment of a fatal encounter.³ The bite that broke the tooth off is frozen in the bone. (The paper is from February; a Montana State release drove the July coverage — the science is not brand-new, but the image is unforgettable.)

THE SCEPTIC

Mind the word "confirmed." This month also brought the strongest evidence yet that a rocky habitable-zone planet, the super-Earth LHS 1140 b, *holds* an atmosphere — but the signal is escaping helium, indirect, and a separate reanalysis of its sibling LHS 1140 c found "no evidence of an atmosphere" at all.⁴ The pattern repeats across the far edges: the well-measured, deflating reading (the *Iliad* scrap as packing; a helium hint, not a confirmed sky) keeps out-lasting the thrilling one. Wonder, then verify.

SOURCES 1 University of Barcelona mission via Smithsonian Magazine, ~13–15 Jul 2026 (*Iliad* "Catalogue of Ships" papyrus on a Roman-era mummy's abdomen, Oxyrhynchus — single research group; "used in embalming/for the afterlife" is the team's interpretation). 2 Classics/archaeology commentary, Jul 2026 (deliberate-vs-recycled debate, characterised from coverage). 3 PeerJ (paper Feb 2026); Montana State University press release, 14 Jul 2026 (*Edmontosaurus* skull MOR 1627, Hell Creek; tyrannosaur tooth crown embedded in the nasal bone, no healing) — publicity, not the science, is July. 4 EarthSky / *Science*, ~16–21 Jul 2026 (LHS 1140 b escaping-helium atmosphere signature — indirect); arXiv reanalysis (LHS 1140 c "no evidence of an atmosphere"). Interstellar comet 3I/ATLAS (older than the Sun) now a past callback (No. 51).

LOVE & LIFE · THE EXAMINED LIFE

The Companion That Deepens the Loneliness

A year-long study across four countries found that turning to an AI companion for comfort predicts not less loneliness but more — the short-term balm and the long-term cost pointing in opposite directions. A quiet preview of the world an eleven-year-old will inherit.

The most sobering relationship finding of the year is also the most counter-intuitive, and it deserves a slow read. In a twelve-month longitudinal study across four English-speaking countries, published this year in *Psychological Science*, the researchers Folk and Dunn found that heavier use of companion chatbots was associated not with less loneliness over time but with *more* — and with less human socialising alongside it.¹ That cuts against the earlier, cheerier studies that measured only the moment of use, when a warm, always-available listener genuinely soothes. The comfort is real; the trajectory is the warning. Something that reliably makes you feel better tonight can quietly make you lonelier by the season, because each easy exchange with a machine is a harder conversation with a person not had.

For a mid-40s reader the sharper angle is generational. The same cohort turning to AI companions in droves (p14) is the one this loneliness data worries about, and it sits inside a broader retreat: only about 31% of young adults are actively dating, money the most-cited barrier, and roughly a quarter of adults worldwide feel lonely "a lot," young Singaporeans among the loneliest of all.² The examined-life reading is not that intimacy is dying but that a machine now stands where the friction

used to be — and the friction, it turns out, was doing something.

12 mo

THE STUDY WINDOW OVER WHICH HEAVIER AI-COMPANION USE TRACKED WITH *RIISING* LONELINESS AND LESS HUMAN CONTACT (FOLK & DUNN, *PSYCHOLOGICAL SCIENCE*) — THE OPPOSITE OF THE IN-THE-MOMENT RELIEF.

THE CHATTER

Across the dating subreddits and the culture press the mood is less despair than fatigue: app burnout, a swing to "slow" off-app dating through hobbies and run clubs, and a wariness of the frictionless option. On the AI-companion thread the more thoughtful line is that the bot is fine as a supplement and dangerous as a substitute — a distinction, users note, easy to blur at 1am.³

THE SCEPTIC

Handle it all with tongs. The companion study is correlational — lonely people may simply reach for a chatbot more, not the reverse — and much of the surrounding "dating recession" data is self-reported, some of it PR-commissioned by companies with a stake in the story. There is even a counter-case: the American Friendship Project found ~98% of adults report at least one friend, arguing the "loneliness epidemic" hinges on survey wording. The direction is real; the precision is borrowed confidence.⁴

THE SINGAPORE LINE

The local data points the same way. SingStat recorded 26,328 marriages in 2024, down 7% on the year, with the median age at first marriage now 31.1 for men and 29.6 for women; the IPS loneliness poll put youth isolation well above older cohorts.⁵ Directional, and older than this month — but it frames the finding for a Singapore reader: the market for a machine that never cancels a plan is real, and growing.

SOURCES — 1 Folk & Dunn, *Psychological Science*, 2026 (DOI:10.1177/09567976261427747) — 12-month longitudinal, four English-speaking countries; heavier companion-chatbot use associated with worsening loneliness and less human socialising. 2 Institute for Family Studies / Wheatley Institute, *State of Our Unions 2026* (~31% actively dating; money the top barrier); Gallup / Meta-Gallup, 2024–25 (~23% globally feel lonely "a lot") — self-report. 3 Dating subreddits and culture-press discussion, Jul 2026 (characterised from coverage). 4 American Friendship Project via phys.org, 2024 (~98% report ≥1 friend — the counter-case); correlational caveat on companion study. 5 SingStat, Statistics on Marriages & Divorces, 7 Jul 2025 (26,328 marriages 2024, -7.0%; median first-marriage age 31.1 M / 29.6 F); IPS (NUS) loneliness poll, 2023–24. Directional; general observation, not advice.

AI COMPANIONS

LONELINESS

SELF-REPORT

THE EXAMINED-LIFE READ

Set beside the family desk's companion worry (p14), a single pattern emerges across two generations: the frictionless option feels like the cure and behaves like the cause. The durable point is not that connection is dying but that it is *re-forming* around a choice — between the easy exchange that asks nothing and the harder one that asks everything, and slowly gives it back.

FITNESS · THE LONG GAME

We're Buying Extra Years, and Spending Them Sick

Life expectancy keeps rising; the trouble is that the added years are increasingly lived in poor health. The fix is not a new molecule but the dull, well-evidenced levers — and a warning about the "biological age" number your ring keeps showing you.

The number that should organise a mid-40s reader's thinking is not lifespan but the gap beneath it. Fresh coverage this month put the *healthspan* problem plainly: life expectancy is still climbing, but the extra years are increasingly spent in poor health — chronic pain, lost strength, rising rates of depression and anxiety in later life.¹ The distinction is the whole game. Nobody at forty-five is really optimising for a longer death; the target is more *good* years — and the levers that buy those are boringly well established, and none of them come in a bottle.

Two of them are worth banking. Muscular strength independently predicts a lower risk of dying: a JAMA analysis this year found the strongest-grip group had roughly a third lower mortality.² And a Harvard analysis in *BMJ Medicine* found that *variety* of exercise — not merely total minutes — was linked to about 19% lower premature-death risk than the least-varied. Both are observational, so read the doses as targets, not proofs of cause; but they point the same way as the whole evidence base, and the same way as a lifetime of gym lore that predates it.

~33%

LOWER MORTALITY IN THE STRONGEST-GRIP GROUP (JAMA, 2026); RISK FELL ~15% PER 7KG OF GRIP GAINED. STRENGTH, BANKED EARLY, IS THE CHEAPEST HEALTHSPAN INSURANCE THERE IS.

WHAT THE RING GETS RIGHT

The wearables are not useless — they are just measuring the wrong headline. A 2025 validation over 536 nights found the Oura Gen 4 tracked nocturnal resting heart rate and HRV almost perfectly (concordance 0.98–0.99), with Whoop close behind.⁵ Trust the raw physiological trends the device measures; treat the composite "age" score it computes as a motivational toy. (Small study, n=13 — directional.)

SOURCES 1 Healio, 23 Jul 2026 (life expectancy rising, added years increasingly in poor health) — single-outlet secondary reporting; underlying journal unconfirmed, framing flagged as directional. 2 JAMA Network Open, Feb 2026 (~5,472 women 63–99; highest-grip group ~33% lower mortality; ~15% per 7kg grip) — observational; older-women cohort, directional for mid-40s. 3 *r/longevity*, *r/Whoop*, *r/ouraring*, Jul 2026 (characterised from community context). 4 *Nature Communications*, Dec 2025 (14 epigenetic clocks, 174 outcomes, ±3–5 yr disagreement); Inc., 2026 (O. Zolman; N. Barzilai); PEARL rapamycin trial (PMC), 2026 (primary endpoint not met). 5 *Physiological Reports* (Wiley), 2025 (536 nights, n=13; Oura Gen 4 nocturnal HR CCC 0.98 / HRV 0.99; Whoop 0.91 / 0.94). 6 *Sports Medicine*, 2025, "Much Ado About Zone 2." Educational summary; general guidance, not medical advice.

THE CHATTER

Across *r/longevity*, *r/Whoop* and *r/ouraring* the running 2026 gripe is that the new "Biological Age" and "Cardiovascular Age" scores disagree wildly device-to-device — "it's a vibe, not a measurement" — and the supplement threads have curdled toward "save your money and train instead." The consensus that survives every hype cycle is unglamorous: lift, move variously, protect sleep, eat enough protein.³

THE SCEPTIC

Distrust the age on the dashboard. A December 2025 *Nature Communications* analysis of fourteen epigenetic "clocks" across 174 disease outcomes found they disagree substantially, with errors of three-to-five years — and Oliver Zolman, once of Bryan Johnson's Blueprint team, warns people "think they're healthy because some random markers say their biological age is young."⁴ Nir Barzilai is blunter still: hormone-maintenance interventions "do not grow your lifespan," and rapamycin's flagship human trial just missed its primary endpoint. The behaviour out-evidences the biomarker. General guidance, not medical advice.

HEALTHSPAN

TRAIN, DON'T TEST

NOT MEDICAL ADVICE

A WORD ON ZONE 2

The reader-favourite steady-cardio gospel got a contrarian poke: a 2025 *Sports Medicine* review, "Much Ado About Zone 2," argued the evidence does *not* single out Zone 2 as the optimal intensity for mitochondrial or cardiorespiratory gains, and that higher intensities may deliver more per hour.⁶ Not a reason to abandon easy miles — a reason not to treat them as magic. Variety, again, is the winning bet.

THE TRAVEL DESK • DEPARTURES

Changi Draws Up Its Pre-Terminal-5 Wish List

Ahead of the fifth terminal, the airport has floated six under-served routes it wants flown — while KrisFlyer quietly walls off award searches for near-empty accounts, and Singapore Airlines reshuffles its widebodies for the autumn.

Changi has started shopping for routes. Ahead of the mid-2030s opening of Terminal 5 — Phase 1 alone is sized for some fifty million passengers a year — the airport this month named six under-served destinations it would like carriers to fly: Banda Aceh and Banjarmasin in Indonesia, Hai Phong and Da Lat in Vietnam, and Almaty and Tashkent in Central Asia.¹ It is a wish list, not a timetable, but it reads the way Changi's ambitions usually do — filling in the near-region's gaps and reaching quietly toward the Silk Road cities that a hub with spare capacity can afford to court. For a Singapore flyer, the practical news is closer in: the widebodies are being shuffled for the season.

From the start of July, Singapore Airlines moved all six daily Bangkok flights to the 787-10, put an A350-900 on one of its London Heathrow rotations and took Manchester to a daily service, with a short A380-to-777 swap on a Mumbai run through late August.² The lounges are catching up too: the refreshed SilverKris Business Class Lounge in Terminal 2 has soft-opened, part of a S\$45 million revamp due to finish by year-end. (Treat the deployment specifics as reported from schedule trackers, not a booking guarantee.)

POINTS & THE FARE PEG

KrisFlyer's award chart devalued last November (Saver +~5%, Advantage +10–15%), with pre-devaluation pricing bookable only to 21 October 2026 — the window to burn miles is closing.⁵ **A live fare peg:** Scoot has been added to SIA's "Spontaneous Escapes," 30% off select Saver awards for travel 1–31 August, book by 31 July. And Scoot has resumed a direct Singapore–Pontianak service, ending the transit routing to West Kalimantan.

6

UNDER-SERVED ROUTES CHANGI WANTS FLOWN BEFORE TERMINAL 5 — BANDA ACEH, BANJARMASIN, HAI PHONG, DA LAT, ALMATY AND TASHKENT — A HUB WITH SPARE CAPACITY COURTING THE NEAR-REGION AND THE SILK ROAD AT ONCE.

THE CHATTER

The talking point on FlyerTalk and the points blogs is quieter and more annoying: KrisFlyer appears to have started blocking Saver award searches for accounts holding fewer than 1,000 miles, from around 21 July — read by members as a move against third-party award-alert tools and burner accounts. Singapore Airlines has not announced it, so treat it as reported member behaviour, not confirmed policy.³

THE FINE PRINT

Two corrections to keep the file honest. Singapore Airlines' long-awaited new First and Business suites have slipped to 2027 — do not plan a 2026 trip around them. And **Jetstar Asia remains closed:** the intra-Asia arm shut in mid-2025 and has not resumed, so it flies none of these routes. Book on what is scheduled and confirmed, not on a refresh that keeps receding.⁴

NEW ROUTES

LOUNGE

POINTS

ENTRY RULES • DELTA ONLY

Japan's departure tax is reported rising to ¥3,000 (from ¥1,000) — but that originates in a tax-reform outline, so treat the start date as proposed, not legislated, and verify against Japan's finance ministry before you count on the old rate.⁶ **Europe:** the EES biometric border is live; ETIAS is now slated for the last quarter of 2026. **Bali's** levy is unchanged at IDR 150,000; **Thailand's** TDAC arrival card is mandatory, free, and only via the official site — the fee sites are scams.

SOURCES 1 The Star, 14 Jul 2026; Aviation A2Z, 15 Jul 2026 (Changi's six under-served target routes ahead of Terminal 5); Business Traveller (T5 Phase 1 ~50m pax, mid-2030s). 2 Travel And Tour World / Aviation A2Z, 2026 (SIA July deployment swaps — secondary aggregators, not primary-verified); Mainly Miles, 24 Jul 2026 (fleet/traffic); The MileLion, 17 May 2026 (SilverKris T2 Business Lounge soft-open, S\$45m revamp); LTA (RTS Link ~90%, end-2026 target). 3 LoyaltyLobby; The MileLion, 21 Jul 2026 (KrisFlyer <1,000-mile award-search block — airline-unconfirmed, member-reported); FlyerTalk. 4 The MileLion, 5 May 2026 (SIA new First/Business slipped to 2027); Qantas Newsroom, 2025 (Jetstar Asia closed 31 Jul 2025, not resumed). 5 Mainly Miles, 2025 (KrisFlyer devaluation 1 Nov 2025; pre-deval pricing to 21 Oct 2026); LoyaltyLobby, 15 Jul 2026 (Spontaneous Escapes); Indiplomacy, 3 Jul 2026 (Scoot Singapore–Pontianak). 6 Travel Voice / Travel And Tour World, 2026 (Japan departure tax → ¥3,000 in the FY2026 tax-reform outline — proposal stage, verify with Japan MOF); Morgan Lewis / Fragomen (EES live, ETIAS Q4 2026); The Bali Sun (Bali levy unchanged); ThaiEmbassy (TDAC free, official site only).

JAPAN REDISCOVERS THE OVERNIGHT TRAIN

The most romantic travel news of the month runs on rails. Japan is reviving the sleeper: JR East has announced a "Luna Azul" overnight service toward Aomori, and a new "Tokaido Lumiere Express" between Tokyo and Osaka debuts on 8 August, departing at ten at night and arriving just before seven — the night train reborn as an experience rather than a necessity.¹ From October the Tokaido Shinkansen also rolls out fully-enclosed private cabins on its premium carriages. And the long argument over the Hokuriku Shinkansen's extension was settled in mid-July: the line will reach Osaka via Kyoto, on the Obama-Kyoto alignment — a route decades from completion, but a decision at last.

WHERE THE ROOMS ARE OPENING

The hotel pipeline keeps pushing past the obvious cities. In the window, the Grand Mandy Tokyo Bay resort opened on 18 July near the Tokyo Disney Resort — 140 full-ocean-view rooms built for families of four to six — though that one rests on a single secondary source, so verify before you book.² It sits alongside the broader 2026 wave the Good Life tracked (p11): the biophilic 1 Hotel Tokyo and the Waldorf Astoria Osaka, the soft yen (p15) flattering the room rate as much as the shopping.

The night train, reborn as an experience rather than a necessity — the most romantic travel news of a month otherwise full of tariffs and fine print.

THE NEAR-REGION KEEPS FILLING IN

Underneath the marquee announcements, the workhorse network thickened. Singapore Airlines Group carried 4.1% more passengers in June than a year earlier on 6% more capacity, for an 87% load factor — full aircraft, not empty ambition — while Scoot returned two of its grounded A320neo-family jets to service and kept adding thin near-region routes, the Pontianak resumption (p19) the latest thread.³ For a flyer, the practical peg is the fare, not the fleet: SIA's "Spontaneous Escapes" now includes Scoot, 30% off select Saver awards for August travel, booked by 31 July — a genuine window to burn miles before the award chart's pre-devaluation pricing closes in October.

~5 min

THE JOHOR BAHRU-WOODLANDS CROSSING THE RTS LINK WILL RUN AT UP TO 10,000 PASSENGERS AN HOUR EACH WAY — ~90% BUILT, TARGETING END-2026, THE SINGLE MOST CONSEQUENTIAL 2026 OPENING FOR A HOUSEHOLD THAT DRIVES NORTH.

CHECK BEFORE YOU FLY

Two live disruptions worth a glance if a European leg is on the cards: Italy ran national aviation strikes on 5 and 21 July, and broader European air-traffic-control and ground strain produced delays at the big hubs through late July.⁴ None of it should reshape an autumn plan, but it is the kind of thing to check the morning you leave. On gear — the eSIM, the carry-on, the noise-cancelling — the file lives on The Kit (p9), not here; the desks hand off rather than duplicate.

THE CHATTER

Two threads are running warm. The rail crowd is quietly thrilled at Japan's sleeper revival — the overnight train reframed from cheap transport to a bookable experience, with the FlyerTalk and rail-forum consensus that the new premium cabins will sell out on novelty long before they settle into a schedule.⁶ And for a Singapore household the RTS Link is the one everyone actually asks about: a five-minute hop to Johor Bahru that could rewrite the weekend, if the end-2026 date holds — which, the veterans note drily, is exactly the sort of date that has moved before.

THE HAND-OFF

This is where the supplement points onward. The travel developments above set the landscape — the routes, the rooms, the rules; the deep dive overleaf takes one destination and goes past the listicle. This weekend it is **Seoul** (p21): the great city an easy six hours north, and the honest case — heat, monsoon and all — for going in October rather than now.

IN BRIEF · THE FINE PRINT, FILED

Cabins: the Tokaido Shinkansen's fully-enclosed private compartments arrive from October, a new class of comfort on the Tokyo–Osaka run.⁵ **Lounges:** Changi's refreshed SilverKris and the Jewel works advance on schedule (p19). **Rooms:** the wider 2026 Japan hotel wave — 1 Hotel Tokyo, the Waldorf Astoria Osaka — sits on The Good Life (p11), the soft yen flattering the rate. Carried as continuity, not re-argued.

SOURCES 1 Japan Today; FTN News, 2026 (JR East "Luna Azul"; "Tokaido Lumiere Express" Tokyo–Osaka debuts 8 Aug 2026); Japan Times, 15 Jul 2026 (Hokuriku Shinkansen Kyoto/Obama alignment decided). 2 Explera; Euronews, 2026 (Grand Mandy Tokyo Bay Maihama Resort opens 18 Jul — single secondary source, flagged). 3 Mainly Miles, 24 Jul 2026 (SIA Group June traffic +4.1% pax, LF 87.1%; Scoot returns 2 A320neo); LoyaltyLobby, 15 Jul 2026 (Spontaneous Escapes 30% off, book by 31 Jul). 4 AirAdvisor strike tracker; Wego, Jul 2026 (Italy aviation strikes 5 & 21 Jul; European ATC/ground strain late July) — secondary aggregators. 5 The Traveler, 2026 (Tokaido Shinkansen private cabins from Oct 2026); LTA (RTS Link ~5-min crossing, up to 10,000 pax/peak-hr, ~90% complete, end-2026 target). 6 FlyerTalk / rail-forum sentiment, Jul 2026 (Japan sleeper revival; RTS Link anticipation — characterised from community context, not a quoted thread).

THE GRAND TOUR · SEOUL

The Great City Six Hours North

Seoul is close, cheap for what it gives, and — the honest part — miserable to visit in the season you are reading this. The deep dive: when to actually go, where to base, and why the camera pilgrimage isn't the one you think.

Begin with the inconvenient truth, because a useful guide owes you that before it owes you a list. Late July and August are the wrong months for Seoul. The city sits inside its *jangma* monsoon into the end of July — sixteen-odd rain days, humidity in the high seventies — and August is hotter still, with a second band of heavy rain that can wash out an afternoon without warning.¹ Everyone who has gone in high summer says the same thing: plan indoors, move at dawn, expect a soaked day or two. The windows worth chasing are elsewhere on the calendar — the autumn foliage from roughly 20 October into mid-November, urban peak around the 5th to 15th, and the cherry blossom in the first two weeks of April. Read this now; go then.

Getting there is the easy part. It is a six-and-a-half-hour non-stop from Changi, flown by Singapore Airlines, Asiana, Korean Air, Scoot, T'way and Jeju Air, so the fare ranges from budget to full-service depending only on how much legroom you are willing to buy.² (Exact fares and the won rate move too fast to print honestly here — pull them live before

you book; the Macro Desk's dollar read on p15 is the direction of travel.) Land at Incheon, not the closer-in Gimpo, for the long-haul. Then the only real decision is where to sleep, and it matters more in Seoul than most cities, because the neighbourhoods are genuinely different countries.

~6.5h

NON-STOP FROM SINGAPORE TO INCHEON — SEOUL IS A SHORT-HAUL CITY THAT READS LIKE A LONG-HAUL ONE. BUT GO IN OCTOBER OR APRIL; THE SUMMER YOU ARE READING THIS IN IS THE WRONG SEASON.

WHERE TO BASE — THE HONEST VERSION

Insadong is the balanced pick for a week — central, cultural, walkable. Skip **Myeongdong** as a base: it is a shopping corridor with hard-sell skincare and tourist mark-ups. And when the guidebooks send you to **Bukchon's** restored hanok lanes, go one hill over to **Seochon** instead — the same tiled roofs, but lived-in streets, real cafés and a fraction of the crowds. **Hongdae** is young and loud; **Gangnam** is where the luxury and the Michelin cluster.³

GO IN OCTOBER

BASE: SEOCHON

6.5H NON-STOP

THE CAMERA PILGRIMAGE, HONESTLY

The reader who plans a trip around cameras should know two things before Seoul disappoints him. The real photography quarter is **Chungmuro** — a cluster of analogue shops along Supyo-ro, and the Leica Store Seoul, Korea's first, thirty years old.⁴ But the honest consensus in the trip reports is that Seoul *underwhelms* for used gear next to Tokyo's Map Camera, and film runs pricier. And **Yongsan Electronics Market**, once the pilgrimage, entered demolition in 2025 — worth a look as spectacle, not as a place to buy anything you couldn't get cheaper online.

A NOTE ON MONEY

Seoul is not Tokyo-expensive. Mid-range by big-Asian-city standards — a serious meal costs real money, but markets, transport and a good hotel are gentler than the yen city to its east, and the T-money transit card makes getting around almost free by comparison.⁵ Treat any hard figure you see quoted (including here) as a starting point to verify live: the won has moved, and the honest guide holds the number rather than printing a stale one.

SOURCES 1 visit.seoul.kr; Weather Atlas; Seoul Tourism Organization, 2026 (jangma monsoon into late July, ~16 rain days; August hotter with a second rain band; autumn foliage ~20 Oct–20 Nov, urban peak ~5–15 Nov; blossom early April) — captured via search summaries; verify live. 2 Trip.com / FlightConnections (SIN–ICN ~6h27–6h50 non-stop; SIA, Asiana, Korean Air, Scoot, T'way, Jeju Air). Fares and SGD/KRW deliberately held — pull live before booking. 3 The Invisible Tourist; CityUnscripted; South Korea Hallyu, 2026 (neighbourhood trade-offs: Insadong balanced, Myeongdong touristy, Seochon over Bukchon, Hongdae/Gangnam). 4 Leica Camera store directory; film-community trip reports (Chungmuro camera street; Leica Store Seoul); Korea Herald, 2025 (Yongsan Electronics Market decline/demolition). 5 Cost framing summarised from destination guides; specific figures held pending live verification. Forum sentiment characterised from trip-report consensus, not a single quoted thread.

GETTING AROUND IS THE EASY PART

Seoul is a walker's city stitched together by one of the world's best subways — clean, signed in English, and cheap, with a rechargeable T-money card that also works the buses and most taxis. From Incheon the AREX rail line runs an express and an all-stops service into the centre; take a taxi if you land late, the express if you land in daylight. The thing the maps hide is how *compact* the good parts are: a base in Insadong or Seochon puts the palaces, the market food and the hanok lanes inside a walkable ring, and the metro handles everything beyond it. Save the car-hire instinct for the day trips; in the city itself, feet and the T-money card are the whole toolkit.¹

EAT AT THE MARKET, NOT THE MALL

The single best thing to do in Seoul is also the cheapest. **Gwangjang Market**, trading since 1905, is where to seek the city's signature street food — yukhoe (beef tartare), bindaetteok (mung-bean pancake) and mayak gimhap — with a Michelin Bib Gourmand, the third-generation Buchon Yukhoe, in among the stalls.² For a less-touristed, cheaper version go to **Mangwon Market** near Hongdae, where the crowds are local. The high end clusters in Gangnam — Mingles, Mosu — and the app locals actually use to book it is Catchtable, not the concierge. The honest note the forums add: Gwangjang has grown touristy and a little overpriced at the famous stalls, so wander past the first row.

WITH AN ELEVEN-YEAR-OLD

Seoul is one of the easiest big cities in Asia to travel with a child — genuinely safe, spotless on the metro, and stacked with things a tween will actually remember. **Lotte World** (part indoor, weather-proof for a rainy day) and **Everland** outside the city are the theme parks; **N Seoul Tower** on Namsan is the view; a *jjimjilbang* bathhouse is the cultural oddity she will talk about for a year.³ The palaces — Gyeongbokgung foremost — reward an early start and a rented hanbok, which gets you in free and makes the photographs.

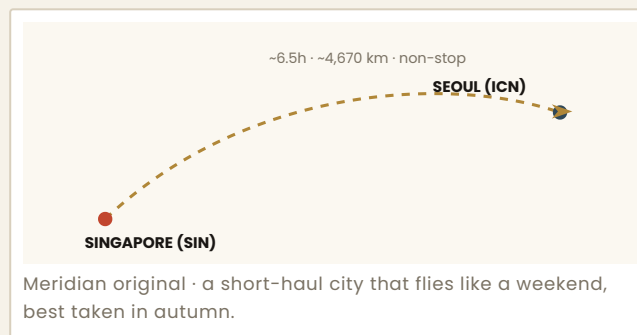
THE DAYS THAT EARN THE TRIP

Past the theme parks, three experiences are worth building a day around. The **palaces at dawn** — Gyeongbokgung and the smaller, lovelier Changdeokgung with its Secret Garden — before the tour buses; the changing-of-the-guard is timed and

photogenic. A **day in the mountains**: Bukhansan National Park is a metro ride from downtown, a genuine granite hike with the city laid out below, the sort of thing no other megacity offers on its doorstep. And the **DMZ**, honestly caveated — the standard bus tour can underwhelm (long transfers, brief stops), and the full Joint Security Area visit, the one worth the trip, runs only intermittently, so check its status before you count on it. Choose two of the three; a week does not stretch to all of it done well.⁴

2 of 3

THE HONEST RATION FOR A FIRST WEEK — PALACES AT DAWN, A BUKHANSAN HIKE, A DMZ DAY — PLUS THE MARKETS AND ONE THEME PARK. SEOUL REWARDS CHOOSING, NOT CRAMMING.



WHAT THE FORUMS ACTUALLY SAY

Strip the guidebooks away and the trip-report consensus is consistent: Myeongdong is a tourist trap (go for the energy, not the shopping); Bukchon is beautiful and overrun, so Seochon wins; the DMZ day-trip *can* underwhelm — long bus, brief stops — unless the full JSA tour is running, which is worth checking before you commit; and everyone agrees Seoul is astonishingly safe and easy with kids. The city rewards a walker and punishes a box-ticker.⁵

HOLD THESE LOOSELY

An honesty ledger, because the research on this one hit hard blocks. The fares, the won rate, the ticket prices and the day-by-day budget are *held* here on purpose — pull them live, because a stale number is worse than none. The camera-and-electronics scene is real but past its prime (verify a shop still trades before you make a special trip). And the forum reads above are the consensus of trip reports, characterised in our own words — not quoted threads. Go for October's light; verify everything with a price on it.

SOURCES 1 Destination guides / Seoul Metro & AREX info, 2026 (subway, T-money card, AREX express vs all-stop from Incheon) — general destination knowledge; verify current fares live. 2 visit.seoul.kr, "Gwangjang Market food guide" (yukhoe, bindaetteok, mayak gimhap; Buchon Yukhoe, Michelin Bib Gourmand); Pixidia / South Korea Hallyu (Mangwon Market); TripAdvisor Seoul Michelin listings (Mingles, Mosu; Catchtable). 3 Destination guides, 2026 (Lotte World, Everland, N Seoul Tower, jjimjilbang, Gyeongbokgung + hanbok free entry) — ticket prices held pending live verification. 4 Destination guides / DOC-equivalent trail notes (Changdeokgung Secret Garden; Bukhansan National Park; DMZ/JSA tour caveats) — JSA operation is time-sensitive, verify current status before booking. 5 Trip-report and forum consensus (r/korea, r/seoul, TripAdvisor Seoul forum), characterised in our own words, not quoted; hard claims (fares, prices, tour status) verify against primary sources before travelling.

THE DIARY

The Nearer Nights, and the October Clash

The bookable calendar firms up: Singapore's free late-August Night Festival, a stack of stadium shows into an October squeezed by the first-ever F1 Sprint, and three new tables — two now with verdicts. Book the clashes first.

SINGAPORE

DATED & BOOKABLE

- 21
AUG–
5 SEP

★ **Singapore Night Festival 2026 — Bras Basah · Bugis**

17TH EDITION, THEME "MYTHS & LEGENDS" · PROJECTION-MAPPING ON THE NATIONAL MUSEUM · FREE, NO TICKET · THE IDEAL FAMILY EVENING, NO BALLOT, NO QUEUE
- 9–11
OCT

★ **F1 Singapore Airlines Grand Prix — Marina Bay**

SINGAPORE'S FIRST-EVER SPRINT WEEKEND — RACING EVERY DAY; LANA DEL REY & THE KILLERS HEADLINE THE PADANG · WALKABOUT FROM ~\$148/DAY, SOME GRANDSTANDS SOLD OUT · BUY ONLY VIA SINGAPOREGP.SG
- 2–3
OCT

★ **The Weeknd — After Hours Til Dawn, National Stadium**

TWO NIGHTS, GUESTS CREEPY NUTS · A LATE SHOW, NOT A SCHOOL-NIGHT PICK FOR A TWEEN · BOOK THE ROOM BEFORE THE F1 BUILD-UP EATS THE CITY
- 25
SEP

★ **Post Malone — Big Ass Stadium World Tour, National Stadium**

HIS FIRST FULL HEADLINE SHOW HERE, GUEST DON TOLIVER · THE SEPTEMBER OPENER TO THE STADIUM RUN · ON SALE NOW

The pinch is now on one page: Post Malone in late September, then The Weeknd and the F1 Sprint stacked into the same October fortnight, hotel inventory the scarce resource. The one with no ballot and no bill is the Night Festival — free, outdoors, the easiest marquee of the lot to take an eleven-year-old to.¹

THE TABLE

SINGAPORE'S NEWEST OPENINGS

BLUE BOX CAFÉ BY TIFFANY — ION ORCHARD

Opened 15 July: Tiffany & Co.'s first café in Southeast Asia, menu by Julien Royer of three-Michelin Odette — an *Oeuf à la Coque* with Oscietra, a confit-chicken nod to chicken rice, the Tiffany Burger, all in that robin's-egg blue. First verdicts are in and they are kind-but-cool: Time Out gave it four stars and steered readers to the breakfast or afternoon tea "for the presentation and the atmosphere." Roughly twenty seats — book ahead. Premium Orchard pricing; not halal-certified (verify).

Verdict: the room outshines the plate, and the room is lovely² · **HYPED** **NOW REVIEWED**

MENSHO X — 6 BATTERY ROAD, RAFFLES PLACE

Opened 14 July: the *global* debut of a leaner spin-off from Tokyo's cult Mensho (chef Tomoharu Shono chose Singapore as the testbed) — toripaitan, tsukemen and a "mochi mochi" mazemen on lighter chicken-and-kombu broths. The enthusiast word is genuinely strong (one ramen specialist scored it 100/100), though mainstream critics are still catching up — read it as promising, not proven. CBD, mid-range, expect a lunch queue; not halal (tori/pork broths).

Verdict: early word excellent, one glowing source · **TOKYO IMPORT** **QUEUES**

FOURA — GARDENS BY THE BAY

Opened 9 July on a Blue-Zones, longevity-inspired premise — wellness eating with a Gardens view. It is in every July listing and has no substantive review yet: a scenic room and an on-trend hook, but genuinely too new to call. Verify the halal status and the price before you build an evening around it.

Verdict: too new to call · **WELLNESS** **UNREVIEWED**

THE HYPE CHECK

Two of these three now have real early verdicts (Blue Box "room over plate"; Mensho X strong but single-sourced), which is the honest progress a table earns by being *eaten*, not opened. Foura is days old — flagged too-new, not praised. Rested this issue with no new peg: FreakyNoods and the viral dessert imports (No. 51). Come back when the reviews, not the ribbon-cuttings, are in.

SOURCES 1 Time Out SG, 16 Jul 2026 (Singapore Night Festival 21 Aug–5 Sep, "Myths & Legends," free); Wise / Motorist / Time Out SG, Jul 2026 (F1 Singapore GP 9–11 Oct, first Sprint weekend; Lana Del Rey & The Killers; walkabout from ~\$148); Live Nation SG (The Weeknd 2–3 Oct; Post Malone 25 Sep). 2 The Table: Time Out SG (4/5) & Eatbook, 13–15 Jul 2026 (Blue Box Café by Tiffany, Julien Royer menu); ahboylikerramen & Eatbook, 14 Jul 2026 (Mensho X global debut — single strong review flagged); Eatbook / TheSmartLocal, Jul 2026 (Foura, too new to call) — buzz summarised, halal status unverified for all three.

JAPAN

FIREWORKS, THEN THE AUTUMN CALENDAR

- 1-3
AUG

★ The "Big Three" Hanabi Weekend — Tokyo & Niigata

EDOGAWA & ITABASHI LIGHT TOKYO ON 1 AUG; THEN NAGAOKA'S GRAND FIREWORKS (2-3 AUG), 20,000+ SHELLS AND JAPAN'S SINGLE HARDEST HANABI SEAT TO BALLOT · BOOK PAID SEATING NOW OR DON'T FLY FOR IT
- 13-27
SEP

★ Aki Basho — Grand Sumo Autumn, Ryōgoku Kokugikan, Tokyo

15-DAY TOURNAMENT · TICKETS ON SALE 8 AUGUST · WEEKEND & FINAL-DAY SEATS GO FIRST · GENUINELY FAMILY-FRIENDLY AND QUINTESENTIALLY TOKYO
- 29
AUG

Omagari National Fireworks Competition — Akita

THE 98TH EDITION, THE PYROTECHNICIANS' OWN CHAMPIONSHIP · PAID SEATS BALLOT AND SELL OUT · THE CONNOISSEUR'S HANABI, WORTH THE DETOUR NORTH
- 9-10
OCT

Takayama Autumn Festival — Gifu

ORNATE YATAI FLOATS, KARAKURI PUPPETS, A LANTERN NIGHT PARADE · BOOK TAKAYAMA LODGING EARLY, IT IS A SMALL TOWN · THE AUTUMN MATSURI TO PLAN A TRIP AROUND

The calendar rolls cleanly from summer's fireworks into the autumn festivals: the "Big Three" hanabi across August, then sumo, then the mountain matsuri and — for a family — the two timed-entry hard-to-books, Ghibli Park and teamLab, whose October tickets release around 10 August and sell out before you fly.¹ The currency maths is the one on p15: a firm Singapore dollar against a still-soft yen tilts every sum toward the Tokyo traveller — and the weakness that flatters the shopping flatters the rooms too, so the good ones clear early.

WIDER REGION

WORTH THE FLIGHT

- INTO
OCT

★ Busan International Film Festival — South Korea

ASIA'S LARGEST FILM FESTIVAL · PAIRS THE AUTUMN-FOLIAGE WINDOW WITH THE SEOUL DEEP DIVE ON P21 FOR A KOREA-THEN-JAPAN SWING · THE CULTURE-TRAVELLER'S OCTOBER
- 31
OCT

BIGBANG — 20th-Anniversary World Tour, Sydney

THE GROUP'S ONLY AUSTRALIAN DATE, ACCOR STADIUM · A GENUINE TRAVEL-FOR-IT SHOW FOR A K-POP HOUSEHOLD · JAY CHOU PLAYS MELBOURNE 17 OCT
- 10
AUG

Ghibli Park & teamLab — October dated tickets on sale

TIMED-ENTRY OCTOBER RELEASES AROUND 10 AUG · BOTH SELL OUT WEEKS AHEAD · SET THE ALARM IF A JAPAN TRIP IS ON THE CARDS

An autumn trip can now be shaped around almost anything a family cares for — fireworks in August, sumo in September, the mountain festivals and teamLab in October, a Busan-and-Seoul detour on the way in (p21). The binding constraint stays the yen: the weakness that draws this reader also draws everyone else, so the Tokyo rooms clear well before the sumo tickets even release on 8 August.

PLANNING NOTES

September is the pinch. The Aki Basho and every Tokyo hotel compete for the same three weeks — if a Japan trip is being stitched to a home concert (p23), lock both ends before the 8 August sumo release pulls the inventory.

Family-friendly: the fireworks, the early days of the basho and Ghibli Park travel best with an eleven-year-old; late-night stadium shows, less so.

THE HAND-OFF

The weekend book's travel thread lands here in three passes: the Travel Desk set the destination and the landscape (p19-22); the Macro Desk set the currency that pays for it (p15); and The Diary carries the dated events to book. The Grand Tour supplies the where; this page, the when. Between them: a firm Singapore dollar, a soft yen, and an autumn calendar that rewards booking early over booking well.

FURTHER OUT · ALREADY ON THE CALENDAR

F1 Singapore Grand Prix (9-11 Oct) — the race weekend is the fixed point the October squeeze forms around (p23). **ZoukOut 2026** (2-3 Dec, Siloso Beach) — the festival's 20th anniversary, with Carl Cox, Armin van Buuren and Martin Garrix; early-bird tickets flagged earlier. **Massive Attack** play The Star Theatre on 29 July (p12), the nearest premium pick of all. Carried forward as continuity, not re-explained.²

SOURCES + MATCHA / Japan Cheapo / JRailPass (Nagaoka Grand Fireworks 2-3 Aug; Edogawa & Itabashi 1 Aug; Omagari 29 Aug); Japan Travel / Nihon Sumo Kyokai (Aki Basho 13-27 Sep, tickets 8 Aug); MATCHA / Odynovo (Takayama Autumn Festival 9-10 Oct); teamLab / Ghibli Park (October tickets ~10 Aug); USD/JPY via TradingEconomics, Jul 2026. 2 Backseat Mafia / RUSSH (BIGBANG Sydney 31 Oct; Jay Chou Melbourne 17 Oct); Busan International Film Festival, 2026; F1 / ZoukOut / Massive Attack carried as continuity — no new peg this issue.

THE LONG READ

The Reckoning

On a Saturday this magazine keeps its own accounts. The habit is older than double-entry, older than money — and its history carries a warning: the ledger you try to burn is the one that comes back to collect.

On the night of 16 October 1834, the Houses of Parliament burned down because a clerk was tidying up the accounts. For nearly six centuries the English Exchequer had recorded the nation's debts on tally sticks — lengths of willow notched to mark a sum, then split down the middle so that Crown and debtor each kept a matching half, a record neither could forge because only the two halves together were legible.¹ The system was abolished in 1826, and eight years later someone decided to be rid of the obsolete sticks by burning them in the coal furnaces beneath the House of Lords. The flues overheated, the panelling caught, and by morning most of the medieval Palace of Westminster was ash. The nation's discarded accounts had, quite literally, burned down its Parliament. Dickens later told it as a parable of bureaucratic vanity — the state clinging to willow twigs into the railway age. It reads better as something stranger: the ledger's refusal to be quietly disposed of.

England had form here. Seven centuries before the fire, the conqueror of that same kingdom had ordered the most complete reckoning any medieval state attempted. The *Domesday Book* of 1086 surveyed who held what and what it was worth, down — the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle grumbled — to the last ox, cow and pig; and its nickname was not administrative but eschatological.² People called it *Domesday*, *Doomsday*, because like the Last Judgment its verdict admitted no appeal. That is the quiet dread at the bottom of every serious ledger: not that it records, but that its record is *final*. A tally you can lose; a *Domesday* you cannot argue with. The English had built, in a book, a small model of the reckoning they believed was coming for them anyway.

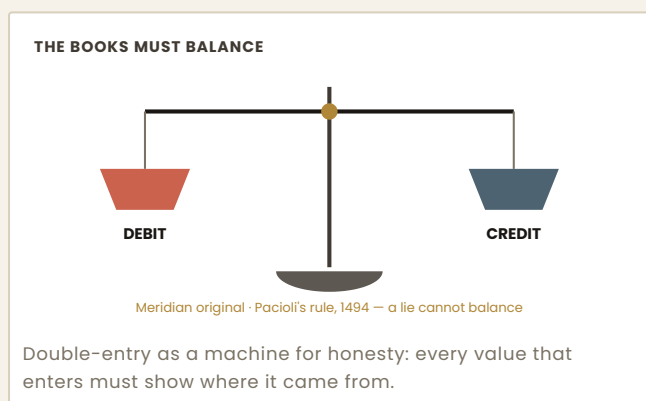
This issue is full of accounts being settled, and mis-kept. Two pages from the front, this magazine grades its own calls on The Scoreboard, misses first, because a publication that will not keep score on itself has no standing to keep score on anyone (p2). Washington sent Singapore a bill this week and wrote "forced labour" in the memo line, a moral ledger entry stapled to a commercial one (p5). A war's oil price has become a running account of fear, marked to market each day the strait stays live (p3, p15). And two desks over sit the subtler books: a companion chatbot that balances tonight's comfort against next season's loneliness and quietly runs a deficit (p17); a wearable that computes a "biological age" flattering enough to make a reader feel solvent (p18). The week's real question is never whether to keep accounts. It is whether to keep them honestly.

The nation's discarded accounts had, quite literally, burned down its Parliament. The ledger you try to burn is the one that comes back to collect.

To ask that question well, it helps to remember what a ledger is *for* — a thing so woven into modern life that we have forgotten it was ever invented. It was, and the invention has a date, a city and an argument attached. The argument is that nothing is free: that every value which enters the world came from somewhere, is owed to someone, and can be written down. It is a moral proposition disguised as an accounting technique, and the three oldest forms of it — a notched stick, a balanced page, and a weighed heart — turn out to be saying the same thing in three registers. The stick says a debt outlives memory. The page says a lie cannot balance. And the heart says that in the end the accounts are kept on you.

SOURCES 1 UK Parliament, "The 1834 fire" (Exchequer tally sticks abolished 1826; obsolete sticks burned in the House of Lords furnaces, 16 Oct 1834, destroying most of the medieval Palace of Westminster); Charles Dickens, speech to the Administrative Reform Association, 1855 (the tally-stick parable). 2 *Domesday Book*, commissioned by William I at Christmas 1085, largely completed 1086 (The National Archives, UK; Britannica, "Domesday Book"); the "Doomsday"/no-appeal nickname and the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle's "not one ox" complaint are the standard account. Historical account; details verified against standard references.

The clearest statement of what a ledger is for was printed in Venice in 1494, in a fat mathematics textbook by a Franciscan friar. Luca Pacioli's *Summa de arithmetica* contained, almost as an aside, a twenty-seven-page treatise — "Particularis de computis et scripturis" — that gave the world its first printed description of double-entry bookkeeping.¹ Pacioli did not invent the method; the merchants of Venice and Genoa had used it for two centuries, and he said so plainly. What he did was codify it, and in codifying it he stated its governing law, which is a small moral marvel: every debit must have an equal and opposite credit, and at the close of the books the two columns *must balance*. Nothing may go unaccounted. Every value that enters the page must be matched by a record of where it came from. Goethe, no accountant, called it "one of the finest inventions of the human mind" — and he was right, because it is a machine for honesty, a structure in which a lie, to survive, would have to balance, and a lie will not.²



Return, with that rule in mind, to the willow stick. What made the tally more than a receipt was the split: two halves that only matched each other, so that a debt, once notched, existed independently of either party's memory or goodwill. You could lose a friend, change a king, forget a sum — the stick still balanced against its twin. That is the deep function a ledger performs and a handshake cannot: it makes a claim *durable*, lodged outside the heads of the people it binds. Which is also why it is dangerous to whoever would prefer the record softer. A tally cannot be flattered. And when a state grown embarrassed by its own antique bookkeeping tried, at

last, to make six centuries of debt simply *go away* in a furnace, the debt did the one thing a good ledger is built to do: it would not go quietly. It took the roof with it.

A machine for honesty — a structure in which a lie, to survive, would have to balance. And a lie will not.

It is worth pausing on what that balanced page made possible, because it is easy to mistake bookkeeping for mere record-keeping. Before double-entry, a merchant's wealth lived largely in his own head and his own honesty; a partner across the sea had to take both on faith. Pacioli's columns turned trust into something a stranger could inspect. A Venetian could now send goods to Alexandria in the care of a factor he would never meet, because the books would show, unambiguously, what was owed and to whom — and a merchant who cooked them would be found out the moment the columns failed to close. The great trading republics did not run on trust so much as on the *audit* that let them dispense with it; the ledger was the technology that made commerce possible between people who had no reason to believe one another. Honesty, made mechanical, scales in a way honesty of character never can.

Hold those together — the balanced page and the unforgeable stick — and you have the whole civic case for honest accounts. A ledger is memory the powerful cannot simply edit; it is the reason a debt owed to the weak can outlast the strong; it is how a society remembers what it promised when it would rather not. Every improvement in the technology of accounting, from Pacioli's columns to the tamper-evident logs that run a modern exchange, has been a fresh attempt to build a record that no interested party can quietly revise. And every one of them has been met, sooner or later, by an interested party's attempt to revise it anyway. The history of the ledger is the history of that argument, and it did not end in Venice.

SOURCES 1 Luca Pacioli, *Summa de arithmetica, geometria, proportioni et proportionalità* (Venice, 1494), incl. the treatise "Particularis de computis et scripturis" — the first printed account of Venetian double-entry bookkeeping; Pacioli codified, did not invent, the method (Britannica, "Luca Pacioli"). 2 J. W. von Goethe, *Wilhelm Meister's Apprenticeship* (1795–96) — double-entry bookkeeping as "one of the finest inventions of the human mind"; on the tally stick and "stock"/"stockholder," UK Parliament and the Oxford English Dictionary. Historical account; details verified against standard references.

The oldest ledger of all is kept not on paper or willow but in a hall of judgment, and its rule is stricter than Pacioli's. In the ancient Egyptian *Book of the Dead*, spell 125, the heart of the newly dead is placed on a great scale and weighed against the feather of Ma'at — truth, justice, the order of things — while the ibis-headed scribe-god Thoth records the result and a waiting monster, Ammit, devours the heart that proves too heavy with its owner's sins.¹ It is accountancy rendered as physics: the self, audited; the account, unfalsifiable; the record-keeper a god with a pen. What the Egyptians grasped, four thousand years before a Venetian friar wrote it down, is the thing the tally stick and the balanced page only imply — that every civilisation which learns to keep accounts eventually imagines, with a shiver, the accounts being kept on it. The ledger is never only outward-facing. It is a rehearsal for being read.

Which is why the failure mode, in every age, is the same. It is not the absence of a ledger — humans cannot help keeping them — but the ledger that *flatters*. It is the market-implied odds this magazine printed a touch too confidently and had to mark down on The Scoreboard (p2). It is the wearable that computes a "biological age" young enough to reassure a reader out of the training he actually needs (p18). It is the tariff whose memo line reads "forced labour" over a figure someone simply wished to charge (p5), and the companion chatbot whose books show a warm balance tonight and a widening deficit by the season (p17). A dishonest ledger is worse than no ledger at all, because it launders the lie in the trusted language of accounts. The flattering book always balances — that is the trick of it — right up until the furnace.

And the temptation to keep one is not a moral failing so much as a structural pull, which is why it recurs in every age with a new face. An honest reckoning is, by design, a machine for delivering bad news you would rather not hear — that the position is worse than hoped, the debt larger, the muscle weaker, the peace further off. A flattering one delivers the opposite, in the same authoritative voice, and asks nothing of you but that you keep believing it. Whole systems drift toward the flattering book almost gravitationally: the analyst whose forecast the client wants confirmed,

the platform whose "engagement" metric quietly redefines a good day, the state whose growth figure must be met. Each keeps balancing, immaculately, while the real account it was meant to track slides silently out of true. The failure is rarely a single fraud. It is a thousand small revisions, each defensible, each in the direction of comfort, until the map and the territory are strangers and only an outside shock — a war, a run, a fire — forces the two back into the same room.

A dishonest ledger is worse than none at all: it launders the lie in the trusted language of accounts. The flattering book always balances — until the furnace.

So this is why a magazine keeps a Scoreboard, and keeps it on a Saturday, and prints the misses first. Not to punish itself; the wrong calls are the column's currency, and there will be more of them. It is because the only alternative to an honest reckoning is the flattering one, and the flattering one is the book that eventually takes the roof with it. "The Moving Finger writes," runs the couplet on this issue's contents page, "and, having writ, moves on" — and no piety, no tears, will wash out a word. Read as a threat it is bleak. Read as an accountant would read it, it is simply the founding promise of every ledger ever kept: that the line, once written, is real; that nothing entered the world for free; and that the honest response to a reckoning is neither to flatter it nor to burn it, but to read it down the column — misses first — and pay, in full, what you find you owe.

THE THREADS

The accounts running through this weekend's book: a magazine grading its own calls (p2); a tariff filed under a moral memo (p5); an oil price marking a war to market (p3, p15); the watch room's froth, which is only the market keeping score on itself (p11); and the emotional ledgers two desks apart — the companion that debits next season for tonight's comfort (p17), the wearable that flatters the balance (p18). Different columns, one rule: the entry you refuse to record is the one that comes back to collect.

SOURCES | *The Book of the Dead*, spell (chapter) 125 — the "weighing of the heart" against the feather of Ma'at, overseen by Anubis, recorded by Thoth, with Ammit as devourer (British Museum, the Book of the Dead of Hunefer, c. 1275 BC; Britannica, "Book of the Dead"). Khayyám couplet: *Rubā'iyāt*, FitzGerald trans. (1859), quoted on p2. Historical account; details verified against standard references.

Two accounts closed this week and neither balanced cleanly. Washington entered "forced labour" against a third of the island's trade and called the sum justice; the oil market marked a war to a hundred dollars and back, pricing a fear it cannot audit. This magazine, for its part, marked down a call it had made too boldly. All of it is bookkeeping — the stubborn human insistence that nothing enters the world unowed. And yet the week's best pages resisted the ledger entirely: a line of Homer folded, for no profit, against a body; a market's fireworks that pay out only in the looking; a city six hours north best measured not in won but in the light of an October morning. Keep the accounts honestly — the Scoreboard, the tariff, the barrel. But the entries worth the trip are the ones that never balance, because they were never a transaction. The Moving Finger writes; some of what it writes is a receipt, and some of it is a poem. The work of a weekend is learning to tell them apart.

CONSOLIDATED SOURCES — NO. 52

The World: Times of Israel, New York Times (via UNN), Al Jazeera, PBS NewsHour, CNBC, NBC News, Axios, Moscow Times, Ukrainska Pravda, Washington Post, NPR, UN News / OCHA, WHO, FDD.

Singapore / Property: Malay Mail, The Star, Mothership, MTI, SingStat, Enterprise Singapore / Xinhua, AsiaNews Network, URA, PropNex, 99.co, EdgeProp, Stacked Homes, Yahoo Finance SG, HardwareZone, HDB, MINDEF.

Technology: Cryptobriefing, Interconnects, TechI, Simon Willison, TechTimes, taekim, Medianama, Reuters (via KFGO), Bloomberg, BenchLM, Spectrum AI Lab, Float16, Compute-Market, Local AI Master, Codersera, DigitalApplied, Developers Digest.

The Kit / Connected Home: Smartwatch Insight, Forbes, DC Rainmaker, the5krunner, Gadgets & Wearables, Android Police, Sony press, ProVideo Coalition, Gadget Hacks, Glass Almanac, home-assistant.io, GitHub, Matter Alpha.

Good Life / Screen & Sound: WatchCharts, Luxury Bazaar, WatchCrunch, Worn & Wound, screwdowncrown, Art & Object, GearJunkie, Fratello, Monochrome, Forbes, Variety, Deadline, Box Office Pro, ScreenRant, Shaw Theatres, MovieWeb, Exclaim!.

Family: American Academy of Pediatrics, AAP News, CHOC, University of Adelaide, Psychology Today, Murdoch Children's Research Institute, National Sleep Foundation, Common Sense Media, University of Georgia (via MedicalXpress).

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Macro: Yahoo Finance, Fortune, TradingEconomics, CME FedWatch (via CoinGape), Reuters (MAS poll), MTFX, iShares, Investing.com, Forbes, TradingView, Seeking Alpha, Boston Fed.

Curiosities: Smithsonian Magazine, University of Barcelona mission, PeerJ, Montana State University, EarthSky, Science, arXiv.

Love & Life / Fitness: Psychological Science (Folk & Dunn), Institute for Family Studies, Gallup, phys.org, SingStat, IPS (NUS), Healio, JAMA Network Open, Nature Communications, Inc., Physiological Reports, Sports Medicine.

The Travel Desk: The Star, Aviation A2Z, Mainly Miles, The MileLion, LoyaltyLobby, FlyerTalk, Indiplomacy, LTA, Travel Voice, Morgan Lewis, Japan Today, FTN News, Japan Times, visit.seoul.kr, Weather Atlas, Trip.com, The Invisible Tourist, CityUnscripted, Korea Herald.

Diary / Table: Time Out SG, Wise, Motorist, Live Nation SG, MATCHA, Japan Cheapo, JRailPass, Nihon Sumo Kyokai, Odynovo, teamLab, Backseat Mafia, RUSSH, Eatbook, ahboylikeramen, TheSmartLocal.

The Long Read (The Reckoning): UK Parliament ("The 1834 fire"), Charles Dickens (1855 speech), Britannica (Pacioli; Book of the Dead), the *Summa de arithmetica* (1494), Goethe (*Wilhelm Meister*), British Museum (Book of the Dead of Hunefer), Omar Khayyám (FitzGerald, 1859).